Christmas in Bright Moon

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35112967.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Inspired by Hallmark Christmas Movies, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Light Angst, basically every hallmark christmas movie trope possible, No Homophobia, Getting Together, farm au, Christmas Fluff

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Christmas in Bright Moon

by deirdreshannon

Summary

Sent by her real estate firm, high-powered businesswoman Adora Grayskull visits the small, quaint town of Bright Moon in hopes of securing a desirable property. The only problem? The property is the town's beloved Christmas tree farm, owned by local Catra Driluth—and she isn't going to give it up without a fight.

OR

the one where catradora is in a hallmark christmas movie

The Deal

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Isn't it such a winter wonderland in here, Adora?" Mara bubbled, admiring the festive knickknacks that adorned every corner of her dining room. The emerald boughs of a spruce poked out from the parlor, emitting a refreshing pine fragrance.

Adora unwittingly wrinkled her nose at the scent. "It sure is, Mom." She tried not to cringe at the holiday folderol that surrounded her, but it was a tall order. She always loved stopping at her moms' townhouse to have breakfast with them before work, but as of late she hadn't been one for the Christmas spirit… and, in her family, that simply wouldn't stand.

"You can't hate Christmas forever, Adora," Hope tsked, pouring some steaming coffee into Mara's vintage Santa mug, faded from years of use. She and her wife were perpetually in the holiday mood, starting November 1st, and never ceased trying to convince Adora to stop being such a Scrooge.

I didn't always hate it, Adora scowled, but her moms already knew that. There had been a time—not too long ago—when she had reveled in all of the stupid Christmas rituals, until it was all ruined for her. She didn't want to spoil her moms' fun, but couldn't they understand that Christmas reminded her of heartbreak and broken dreams?

"She won't, love. Even if it takes time." Mara winked at Adora, who defiantly avoided eye contact by staring intently at the scrambled eggs on her plate. She checked her watch, wondering if time would save her from another involuntary heart-to-heart with Mara about moving on from the past and embracing new beginnings. All of that was easy for Mara to say, anyway; she had been in a happy relationship with Hope for 35 years, and planned

dozens of weddings for dozens of lovely couples each year. *She* knew what new beginnings were. But Adora just felt stuck in a neverending cycle of self-pity. At any rate, it was indeed time for her to leave, so she stood up and started to clear her plates from the table.

"Already rushing off, dearie?" Razz, Adora's grandma and Mara's mother, took a seat at the dining table. She had lived with Mara and Hope for the last few years, as it had become too difficult for her to live on her own. "You've hardly spent any time with your poor old Razz, She-Ra." Unfortunately, Razz didn't always know who her family members were. (Adora assumed that She-Ra was an old friend of Razz's, but she wasn't sure.)

"Actually, I have to go to work in a minute, Grandma Razz. My boss asked to meet with me this morning, so I definitely can't be late. But, I promise I'll be back here soon." Adora fixed the collar of her black blazer and grabbed her briefcase.

"It's all right, I ought to open the shop soon, too," Hope remarked, setting down her coffee. She was a florist, and owned a successful flower shop in downtown Manhattan. As her first job, Adora used to help out there in her teens. Conveniently, the business also supplied flowers for Mara's weddings. "Customers will be expecting their poinsettias, as they always are around this time."

"That's because you've got the best poinsettias in the city, honey," Mara beamed at Hope. Then she turned to Adora, "Do you think you might be in line for a promotion? You've been putting in so many hours over there, you certainly deserve it."

"We'll see," Adora wiggled her eyebrows as she slipped into her coat. "Wish me luck." She hugged her moms and Razz goodbye, then hurried to her car, preparing to endure Manhattan's morning rush hour.

Luckily, Adora had no problem arriving at Horde Realty with minutes to spare. She took the elevator up to the 17th floor,

where Hordak's office was. Hordak was the company's CEO, so if he wanted to meet with Adora, hopefully it was because of the reason Mara suggested. Unless he wanted to fire her, of course, but Adora was almost certain that she was in his good graces. She had been a project manager at the agency for five years now, since she was 27, and she was damn good at her job. Her co-workers knew it, too.

At 9:00 on the dot, Adora greeted Hordak's secretary, who ushered her into his office. He donned a crisp black-and-gray suit with a red tie, as per usual. He motioned for Adora to sit down, then delved straight into business.

"Adora, I have an opportunity for you. A twelve-day trip, if it even takes that long. But with your prowess, I doubt it will. All you have to do is close a very important deal."

Trip? Adora grinned, imagining golden sandy beaches and the absence of a New York winter. "I'm listening. What kind of deal?"

"There's a Christmas tree farm. Driluth Farms, I believe it's called, in Bright Moon, Pennsylvania." Adora's mental image of the aforementioned trip began to melt away. Hordak continued, "The property is extremely desirable, and rather large. It's a prime location to develop a mall. You'll just need to convince the owner—Catra Driluth—to sell. And negotiate the price, of course."

"Wait, the owner doesn't want to sell?"

"No, but she'll likely have to. The farm is nearing financial ruin. Still, she insists upon kicking up her feet whenever we try to finalize the deal. Small town people get sentimental about these things, I suppose. That's why we need you to go there, in person, and talk some sense into her."

"I…" Adora balked. A twelve-day trip to the middle of nowhere in Pennsylvania wasn't quite what she was expecting. Plus, small towns were about as high on her list of favorite things as Christmas. "When would I leave?"

"I've booked you a room at the local inn. I'd suggest you get on the road in a few hours, once you've packed."

Adora was taken aback. *A few hours? That's a quick turnaround. But there must be some big incentive here.*

Hordak leaned forward in his chair and clasped his hands together. "Adora, I know that you're looking for a… *higher role* in this firm. If you succeed in closing this deal, we can certainly have a conversation about your place here."

Adora suppressed a sigh as she stared out of the window, noticing how beautiful the city looked from here. Maybe this situation wasn't totally ideal, but it was only for twelve days; most importantly, it would propel her career forward, right? She had to do this.

"I'll do it, Hordak. You can count on me."

Adora grunted as she shoved a red bomber jacket into her suitcase. Clothes were strewn about her Manhattan apartment, as if a tornado had blown through it. Usually, though, the place was well-kept and sleek. It wasn't a penthouse, but it was still impressive, and most importantly, it was Adora's. She had moved in a couple years ago, her comfortable salary from Horde Realty allowing her to upgrade to a more modern abode than her previous apartment. Adora put some of the stray clothes away, knowing she wouldn't want to clean up the mess when she returned home, and packed her suitcase into her blue Subaru.

A long stretch of the drive to Bright Moon took place on a two-lane road with thickets of snow-covered trees on either side. Other cars, as well as rest stops, were sparse. It was actually kind of charming, though it reminded Adora that she'd practically be leaving civilization this week to venture to a town as small as

Bright Moon. Once the New York radio stations went out of range, Adora rummaged through the barrage of CDs in her car's front pocket. Her favorite CD in the collection was once a lovey-dovey mixtape that Huntara had made for her, and she certainly wasn't going to play that for the rest of the car ride. *There I go again, thinking about her.* Huntara had broken up with Adora on Christmas Eve the year prior, so Adora spent pretty much all of that Christmas sobbing at her moms' house. It seemed like Adora's family and friends were all just biding their time for Adora to move on, but how could she? Her relationship of three and a half years was out the window, and—not to mention—Huntara had broken up with her the day before her favorite holiday. Adora *pffed* thinking about the cliché "it's not you, it's me" Huntara gave her that day. If Huntara didn't want to commit, she should have said so earlier. Adora glanced back at the mixtape, stifling the urge to chuck it out of the window, and put in the *Pet Sounds* CD she had stolen from Mara instead.

After about two and a half hours, a highway sign indicated that Bright Moon was the next exit. It also displayed the logo for the Etherian, Bright Moon's only lodging establishment. Adora hoped that it wouldn't be too dingy; as she pulled in, that didn't seem to be a problem, but she did roll her eyes at the plethora of Christmas wreaths that overtook the front of the inn. *Here goes* , she thought as she lifted a suitcase out of her trunk and rolled it into the lobby.

A concierge with short, white-blonde hair wearing a crimson dress with a cutout and a Christmas tree brooch practically pounced on Adora when she saw her come through the door. "Welcome to the Etherian! I'm Scorpia. Please, let me help with those," she bubbled, practically grabbing Adora's bags from her hands. "I'll just check you in at the front really quick, so you can be on your merry way."

"Uhh… t-thank you, I appreciate it," Adora sputtered, flabbergasted by this immediate display of small-town friendliness. It was the kind of thing you only saw in movies. She definitely

wasn’t in New York anymore, that was for sure. “The last name’s Grayskull. On behalf of Horde Realty.”

Scorpia typed on her keyboard, but a puzzled expression befell her as she scanned the computer screen. “Nothing’s coming up for that last name. Maybe I spelled it wrong. Wouldn’t be surprised. Could you—”

“G-R-A-Y-S-K-U-L-L,” Adora hastened, crisply enunciating each letter. Scorpia was nice, but Adora didn’t want to spend any more time in this lobby than she had to. “My boss booked a reservation for me, it has to be there.”

Scorpia typed in the name again, then sucked air through her teeth. Probably not a good sign. “I’m sorry, Ms. Grayskull, we really don’t have any reservation under that name. I can check for a...” Scorpia trailed off as she clicked a few more buttons on her computer. “...Vacancy. Which, I’m very sorry to inform you, we don’t actually have at this time.”

Adora put her head in her hands. *Just great. Hordak* would *leave me high and dry in this podunk town.* Adora was giving an arm and a leg for this company, but Hordak couldn’t even book a reservation properly for Adora (if he had even tried to do it at all). Just then, her disgruntled thoughts were interrupted by the sound of the front door jingling, followed by a few *umphs* , and then… a Christmas tree?

“A little help here?” a husky voice grunted. The Christmas tree no longer obscured Adora’s view, and now she could see a woman, maybe in her early 30’s, carrying the tree into the lobby. She wore a black and grey flannel, and her thick brown hair was tied into a tousled ponytail, a few loose strands framing her face. Her golden-brown skin was dotted with freckles, resembling a starry sky, but most striking were her eyes. One was aquamarine, and the other a luminous gold. *Wow.* Adora hadn’t been this instantly attracted to someone since she met Huntara.

"Catra! You brought the tree!" Scorpia rushed out from behind the desk and grabbed the other end of the Christmas tree, which was at least six feet tall. The two of them tentatively placed it next to the fireplace. "Thank you *so* much, pal. After that *sap-mergency* —you know, with the previous tree—I didn't know what we were gonna do. I mean, it's the twelfth. We need a Christmas tree, for Pete's sake."

"Catra… as in Catra Driluth?" Adora asked slowly. Well, that explained the Christmas tree. *Of course I'd be attracted to the person I'm doing business with. Putting a stop to that right about… now.*

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Yours truly."

Adora cleared her throat, then started, "You're who I'm here to meet, actually. I'm—"

"Adora Grayskull. You're here because your company wants my land." There was an uncomfortable silence as Catra looked Adora directly in the eyes. Adora wagered that Catra wasn't too happy about her being here.

Scorpia, who clearly didn't notice the tension, cut in loudly. "Well, that's great, you two already sort of know each other! But you see, Adora here doesn't exactly have a reservation, and *we* don't exactly have any vacancies. We're in a bit of a pickle." Adora looked down and started picking at her nails, a nervous habit.

"Unfortunate." Catra crossed her arms, and Adora could still feel those beautiful eyes boring into her. *Okay, no , I can't keep thinking of her like that. Even if she's really beautiful. Professionalism, Adora.*

"You guys, I just had a lightbulb moment," Scorpia practically bursted with energy, "Catra, you know how you have that empty guest house on your property? Why don't you just let Adora stay there?"

“Umm…” Adora scratched her head. This really was not what she was expecting for this trip, but what even were her options at this point?

“Uh, yeah, I really don’t know if that’s a good—” Catra attempted to dissuade Scorpia, but didn’t get to finish her thought.

“Well, she’s gotta stay somewhere, right? I really wish *I* could be of more help, but the inn is always booked up during the holiday season. All right, now that that’s settled, let me help you load your bags into Catra’s truck.” Before either Catra or Adora could react, Scorpia was already out the door.

Adora managed a weak smile as she turned to Catra. “I guess it would let me get the full flavor of your property before the firm buys it?”

Catra still glowered at Adora. Her silence made Adora think the answer was definitely going to be no, but the farmer surprised her. “Fine. But don’t assume that your firm *will* be buying it. As you might have guessed, I’m not too happy about the idea of selling the farm, and it’s going to take you a lot more than you think to convince me.” Without waiting for Adora to respond, Catra stormed outside. Adora watched through the window as she climbed into her truck and slammed the door.

Letting out a grand sigh, Adora wondered, what had Hordak gotten her into?

“Welcome to your new humble abode,” Catra snarked, haphazardly dropping Adora’s suitcase on the porch of the guest house. She then fished a key out of her jacket pocket and placed it in Adora’s hand. Adora then took a minute to scan her new surroundings. The guest house resembled a cottage, composed of ochre bricks. White string lights lined the bottom of the roof,

illuminating the roof's soft dusting of snow with a pale glow. Not too far behind the guest house, Adora could see Christmas trees growing row-by-row.

Adora used the key to open the front door and instantly realized how… *Christmas-y* it all was? Obviously, Catra was a Christmas tree farmer, but for some reason, she hadn't seemed like a Christmas fanatic in Adora's mind. That was untrue, though, because the guest house was completely decked out for the season. Mara and Hope would've loved this place, Adora surmised. It wasn't particularly big, essentially being a bedroom (including a small fireplace) with a bathroom attached, but you never would've known from the amount of holly and tinsel present. "Do you always have it so..."

"Decorated? Yeah. Sometimes my friends stay over, and I try to make it feel like home." Catra leaned up against the door, waiting for Adora to respond, but Adora still couldn't wrap her head around *Catra* taking the time to put all of this together. She certainly hadn't known her for long, but she just wouldn't have expected this attention to detail. Apparently, Catra knew exactly what Adora was thinking. "Surprised, princess?"

"*Princess?* "

"Hmmm, what should I call you instead? New York?"

"Maybe we can start with *Adora*?"

Catra shrugged and started out the door. "Feel free to use the fireplace, it gets chilly at night. I'll see you tomorrow, *princess* ." Adora clenched her fist as she watched Catra leave, the newfound nickname giving her a twinge of anger. But before the farmer had completely shut the door, she poked her head back in one last time. "We'll talk in the morning, but let me just tell you something now. If you can't convince me in twelve days, it's over. I won't even entertain the idea of selling anymore. And you can tell Horde Realty they're not getting the land." Then she shut the door.

Adora flopped onto the bed, exasperated. This was going to be a long trip, wasn’t it?

Chapter End Notes

the catradora hallmark movie AU you didn't ask for... but seriously, i've seen so many of these hallmark movies that i just had to write one for the lesbians!

hope you enjoy this story :)

next update: nov 27

Grinch out of Water

Chapter Summary

> Catra shows Adora around Bright Moon and gives her a tour of the farm. Naturally, tension ensues.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora awoke to a persistent knocking at the guest house's door. She stumbled out of bed, still in a half-asleep stupor, and threw open the door to find Catra on the porch. Judging by the darkness outside, it couldn't have been later than 6 a.m.

"Hey, Adora." Catra had the hint of a smirk on her face, and Adora wanted to rub it right off of her. "Rise and shine."

"Can I help you?" Adora replied, yawning. Her travels the day prior really must have tired her, because she felt groggier than ever.

"Breakfast in the main house. If you want it, you'll have to get it now." Catra crossed her arms, giving Adora's "I just woke up" look a once-over. "What? Is rising early not part of your cushy New York lifestyle?" Her tone was saturated with judgement, and though she was exhausted, Adora wasn't going to take that.

"You don't know anything about me, Ms. Driluth," retorted Adora, coldly referring to Catra by her last name only. Catra narrowed her eyes, but stayed silent. "If we're going to be negotiating professionally, I'd appreciate it if you kept your presumptions to yourself." Adora clenched her fists, trying to prevent herself from saying something worse. Admittedly, she also felt a bit goofy for using such formal words, but she had to make her point somehow.

"*Hmph*. Fair enough, princess. I'll see you inside." Catra turned on her heels and shut the door behind her.

Infuriating. One minute she's offering me breakfast, the next she's insulting me. And her stupid nicknames… Adora tried to shake off her annoyance and got ready for the day. She put her disheveled blonde hair into her go-to ponytail, then dressed in a black turtleneck and beige checkered slacks. It had flurried overnight, so she stepped into her fluffy snow boots and walked over to the main farmhouse. The walk only took about two minutes.

Adora found her way into the kitchen and saw Catra cooking eggs at the stove. Her long chestnut hair fell over her shoulders, and she wore a gray flannel. Adora had a fleeting (and guilty) thought about how effortlessly beautiful Catra looked, but was interrupted by a furry friend nuzzling her legs. When she looked down, she saw that it was a ginger cat with bright blue eyes. She leaned down to pet its head, and it gave her a small *purr* in appreciation.

"His name's Melog," Catra said, scooping the cat into her arms. "I found him a couple years ago."

"You're adorable," Adora cooed at Melog. "I've been wanting a cat for a while, but I guess I've just… never found the time to get one."

"Horde Realty is working you to death, huh?" Catra quipped, letting Melog down. "I hear the corporate world is pretty unforgiving."

"I don't mind it," Adora responded, attempting to ignore Catra's snark. "I love my job." The words came out more defensively than she would've liked.

"*Suuuure*." Catra took the pan with eggs off the stove and plopped them onto a plate. "Breakfast is served, by the way."

"Why am I here, Catra?" Adora blurted, not mincing words. Maybe it was abrupt, but the question had been gnawing at her since she

arrived in Bright Moon. “You say you don’t want to sell this farm, so why—”

“I might have to, all right?” Catra took a deep breath, bracing her hands against the kitchen counter. “But if I do, it’s going to be my absolute last resort, believe me.”

“In what way?”

“Since my stepmother died two years ago, I’ve had to run this place on my own. And it’s not like the Christmas tree industry is the most lucrative, so you can imagine what the farm’s finances have looked like. Maybe it’s a lot for one person, but this place is all I’ve got.” Catra’s dichromatic eyes were staring right into Adora’s now, and in them, she could sense a myriad of emotions, but one was clearer than the others. Fear. It sent a shiver down Adora’s spine for a reason she couldn’t quite place.

Adora remained completely still as Catra continued to meet her gaze. Finally, she managed, “That does sound like a lot for one person. And I’m sorry about your stepmother.”

“Yeah, no, it’s more complicated than that.” Catra turned away and spoke softly, as clearly this was tough for her to talk about. “Sharon Weaver was a terrible mother figure. Granted, I guess she did keep this farm afloat for almost 20 years after my dad… Ugh, I don’t know why I’m even telling you all this.”

“It’s all right, Catra.” Adora was surprised that Catra had opened up to her at all, but figured it was wiser to change the subject. “Um, maybe you could give me a full tour of the property today? I’d like to know what I’m working with. It’d be helpful to see the town, too.”

“Do I have to?” Catra grumbled, stirring her coffee as she leaned against the fridge.

“No, but… I’d appreciate it?” Adora twiddled her thumbs, worried she had asked Catra for too much right off the bat. “I could do it myself, I guess, but I don’t really know my way around…” She met

Catra's gaze and hoped that she would finally just agree so Adora didn't have to come up with further justification.

"Fine. I'll show you around town first. But we're leaving in ten minutes, because I have things to get done today." Catra brought her coffee, and Melog, into the living room, leaving Adora to her breakfast. Evidently, that conversation was over.

Bright Moon truly was something out of a movie. Mountain peaks were visible in the horizon, though obscured by some fog. The downtown area comprised a row of attractive small businesses that appeared to be built in the 1930's or so. (Adora could see why Hordak thought this town had potential, though she didn't love the amount of Christmas decorations assailing her senses from all sides.) The bakery on the corner, though, stuck out from the rest. Its exterior was entirely shades of pink and purple. Catra noticed Adora eyeing the bakery, and motioned to it from the sidewalk. "The first stop on our tour is Sugar, Spice, and Sparkles. The local bakery. The townies call it 'S-three', but I'd just call it a stupid name for a business run by a woman pushing thirty-five."

"Can we go in?" Adora didn't wait for Catra to answer before she pushed through the door. Catra threw her arms up in irritation, but still followed along.

A woman with short pink and purple hair (which matched the bakery's interior and exterior, Adora noticed) was putting a chocolate cupcake in a box for a customer. When she looked up and saw Catra, her eyes widened a bit. "...Catra!" She greeted them through gritted teeth. "Fancy seeing you here." She waved goodbye to the customer and then focused her attention on Catra and Adora.

"Well, I do live in this town, Sparkles," Catra fired back. Apparently, Adora wasn't the only one who received nicknames from Catra. "Adora, meet Glimmer. She owns this bakery. Glimmer, meet Adora. She's… it's a long story."

"Not that long," Adora shrugged. "I'm checking out Catra's property for my real estate firm. Since the inn didn't have any vacancies, I'm also staying on the farm while I'm here."

Glimmer held her hand out to Adora. "Nice to meet you." Lowering her voice, she muttered, "I wouldn't want to be in *that* situation." Adora figured Glimmer was referencing the fact that Adora was staying with Catra, and softly giggled in solidarity.

"I'm right here, you know," Catra reminded them dryly.

"I thought I heard a familiar voice! Catra, how have you been?" A man wearing a crop top and a cardigan came in through the kitchen and put his arm around Glimmer's waist.

"You two also know each other?" Adora turned to Catra, who was avoiding eye contact.

"*Know* each other? We used to be in the same band! Cyra forever, right?" Bow leaned over to Adora, "Cyra was the name of our band. And we were *good*, let me tell you."

"It was like, a million years ago," Catra scoffed. "I've hardly sung or played guitar since high school."

"And now *I* teach high schoolers how to sing," Bow bubbled proudly. "I'm the choir director at Bright Moon High School. Speaking of which, school starts soon, so I have to go. It was nice meeting you, Adora." Glimmer kissed Bow goodbye before he left. Judging by the wedding band and diamond ring Glimmer sported, Adora guessed that she and Bow were married.

"Can I get you two anything?" Glimmer asked Catra and Adora. The latter looked up at the menu, where she saw a variety of pastries, as well as lattes.

"Just a caramel latte for me, thanks," Adora answered. Most of the pastries were Christmas-centric, and she didn't need any more reminders of what season it was, thank you very much. Although,

she could admit they looked tasty. Glimmer nodded and started fixing up the latte for Adora.

"Glimmer, the KitchenAid broke again!" Someone who sounded younger shouted from the kitchen. "There's flour everywhere!"

With dread, Glimmer put her palm to her face. "That's Frosta, one of Bow's students. And she's a new hire, but she's still... getting the hang of things. I'll be right back, and then I can get your latte ready." She hurried to the back room, leaving Catra and Adora alone.

"You're a musician, huh?" Adora asked Catra, who curled her lip sheepishly. "You'll have to play for me sometime."

"I-I don't do that stuff anymore," Catra stammered. "I sold my guitar, anyway."

Something about the way she said it made Adora doubtful, but she wasn't going to push any farther. "That's a shame."

Glimmer then returned from the kitchen, albeit with a dusting of flour on her pink apron. After she made Adora's caramel latte, Adora tried to pay, but Glimmer refused. "On the house. Consider it your welcome to Bright Moon." In her peripheral vision, Adora saw Catra dramatically roll her eyes.

"That's really nice of you, Glimmer. Thank you." She and Catra exited the bakery and started walking down the sidewalk. Adora glanced into the shop windows as she passed by. One thing she had noticed about small towns was that all of the boutiques looked suspiciously similar no matter where you were.

"Sparkles was never that nice to *me* during Cyra's band practices. Which, by the way, she insisted on attending every time, even though she wasn't in the band. My God, she followed Bow around like a groupie." Glimmer definitely wasn't Catra's favorite person.

"Seems like it worked out for them, though," Adora pointed out, sipping her latte.

"Yeah, thankfully Bow made the first move and asked her out. I had to put up with their unresolved romantic tension for *far* too long."

Adora was surprised that she and Catra were actually having a quasi-normal conversation, but she couldn't help but tease Catra. "I thought you said all of that was *a million years ago.* You're not still holding a grudge against Glimmer, are you?"

Continuing the lighthearted banter, Catra responded, "It's not really a grudge if we still don't get along." Catra then stopped in her tracks and checked her watch. "It's almost afternoon, and I've gotta go to the farm supply store. I might as well bring you with. You can meet Entrapta, too."

"Fine by me," Adora nodded. The two walked back to Catra's truck, and Adora couldn't stop herself from smiling. Maybe Catra wasn't *so* unbearable.

"Catra! I've got this new tech for you to try out, and you're gonna *love* it." Entrapta's long, violet pigtails swished around ferociously as she rifled through an abundance of contraptions. Apparently, her center of operations was the back room of the farm supply store, and her inventions had completely monopolized the area.

"Thanks, Entrapta. This is Adora, by the way. She's… staying on my farm for a little while." Adora waved awkwardly, mentally noting that Catra was reluctant to tell people why Adora was really there.

"Pleasure to meet you, Adora." Entrapta didn't look up from whatever invention she was enthralled with at the moment. Once she was satisfied with it, she presented the device (which resembled a sprayer) to Catra. "The Chloronator 3000. Makes greening the trees a breeze. Give it a try, won'tcha? If you don't like it, I can always improve it, I mean, that's part of the scientific method—"

"I'm sure it'll be fine," Catra cut off Entrapta's rapid-fire stream of consciousness. "You're a lifesaver. By the way, you should come by the farm soon."

"You bet! I've just gotta finish the Hydro-Emitter 3.0 first. All I have to do is recalibrate the sensors, and then…" Entrapta trailed off as she started tinkering with a different invention. Catra gave Adora a knowing glance and started to leave.

"Once she gets into one of her inventions, her focus goes elsewhere," Catra mentioned to Adora as she stepped up to the driver's seat of her truck. "But she's a good friend when it counts. She and Scorpia really got me through the last few years. And, Entrapta's always letting me test out her inventions on the farm. Honestly, she should be in Silicon Valley or something given how good she is, but she wanted to come back to Bright Moon after she got her PhD."

"Well, it's cool of her to come back here," Adora commented, trying not to judge (even though returning to a town as small as Bright Moon wouldn't have been her choice). "By the way, what's greening?" Adora inquired, not having heard the term before.

"To make sure the trees stay green enough throughout wintertime, we have to spray the trees with a non-toxic paint," Catra explained as she started the truck. "Otherwise they'd turn yellow-ish, and obviously *that* wouldn't sell."

Adora raised an eyebrow. "Huh. I don't know a lot about Christmas trees, so I never would have thought about it, but it makes sense."

"Wait, please tell me your family isn't a fake-tree family," Catra pleaded, her hand flying to her mouth.

"Oh, definitely not. It might surprise you, but my moms are obsessed with everything Christmas, and therefore they always get the 'real thing'. I don't think we've ever gotten a fake tree in my life," Adora recounted.

“Wow, your moms love Christmas? How’d you turn out to be such a Grinch?” Catra snorted.

“Okay, what’s the big deal about not being totally and completely in love with Christmas? *Some* of us just don’t like the whole spectacle of the holidays. There doesn’t always have to be a reason.” Adora crossed her arms, pouting.

“Well, that’s your prerogative, princess,” Catra conceded, eyes on the road ahead. The two were fairly quiet for the rest of the car ride back to Driluth Farms.

After a quick snack, Catra kicked off her tour of the farm. “First, we have the horses,” Catra motioned to a few stables at the front edge of the property.

“Wait, you have horses?” Adora immediately ran over to the stables. She figured that she must have missed this when they drove in last night, since it was dark then.

“Were you a horse girl in high school or something?” Catra smirked, following Adora over to the stables. Adora was letting a white stallion sniff her hand, and he nuzzled against it. “That’s Swift Wind. I think he likes you.”

“He’s so sweet,” Adora giggled as Swift Wind licked her hand. She turned back to Catra, “And for your information, I wasn’t a horse girl in high school. Only in middle school, and maybe a few years before that.”

“Likely story. Maybe I’ll let you ride him sometime, but for now, we’ve got to keep moving if you want to see this whole farm.” Catra kept walking, so Adora ran along to catch up to her.

Aside from the small chicken coop Catra showed Adora, a large part of the farm tour consisted of trees, unsurprisingly. Rows and rows of them. But Adora did think the property had a lot of potential, and she didn’t hesitate to tell Catra that.

“Catra, I can see why my boss was interested in this property. Our firm could do a lot with this. I hear they might turn it into a mall, if you decide to sell.”

Catra’s mouth curved into a frown. “Don’t keep talking about that, okay?”

“Talk about what?”

“How your firm is going to desecrate this property.”

“Oh. I…” Adora’s mouth felt dry, and she couldn’t quite muster words that would be adequate to console Catra. Maybe she had been too tactless.

“My childhood was far from perfect, but this was where I grew up. It’s always been my home.” Catra fixed her gaze on the faint outlines of the mountains in the distance. “And maybe you didn’t get a sense of it today, but Bright Moon cares about this farm. There are people here who depend on it. I guess I just can’t imagine the town—or my life—without it, you know?”

“I’m sorry, Catra.” Adora tried to get Catra to make eye contact with her as they walked, but she wouldn’t.

“How can you be? You’re the one they sent to take this place away, anyway.” Catra hastily trudged a few yards ahead, and Adora took that as a sign that this tour was coming to an end. Catra didn’t want to talk anymore. Adora found her way back to the guest house, giving Catra her space. She supposed that she had seen enough of the property, anyway.

Adora understood where Catra was coming from, but she also had to understand that Horde Realty wasn’t “taking anything away”. If Catra were to sell the farm, that would be her choice. At any rate, the problem wasn’t going to be resolved right now; Adora thought she might as well relax. She kicked off her shoes, hopped on the bed, and scrolled through her phone to kill time. Before long, though, Mara’s name flashed on her phone screen. Adora was

simultaneously glad to see her call while also dreading the Christmas talk that would certainly ensue.

"How's it going over in Pennsylvania, Adora? Is Bright Moon treating you well?" Mara asked her daughter.

"How's the farm?" Hope shouted, probably from the other end of the room, since it sounded like they were on speaker phone.

"Hey, Moms, it's going… fine. I'm actually staying in the farm owner's—Catra's—guest house because the inn reservation didn't go through."

"Oh, Adora, I'm sorry things didn't go as planned. Is the guest house nice?" Hope asked.

"Yeah, you guys would love it. Tons of Christmas decorations."

"Sounds like Catra would fit right in around here. Do you think she's cute?" Mara joked, without missing a beat.

"*Mom,*" Adora scolded, thankful that they couldn't see her blushing right now. The answer was "yes", but admitting that to her moms? Forget it. "I'm not supposed to be unprofessional. Also, Catra's kind of difficult. She doesn't even want to sell the farm." *Kind of difficult* was putting it lightly, but Adora didn't have the mental energy to detail the day's events over the phone.

"You know Mara's never going to stop trying to be your wingwoman, Adora," Hope chuckled. "Well, I hope things improve with Catra, and that this deal works out for everyone."

It won't, Adora grimaced. *Either I get what I want, or Catra does.* "Yeah, I hope so," she muttered weakly. "How are things back home?"

"Mara's got a few Christmas weddings to finalize, and the shop's been getting a lot of traffic too," Hope said. "But in the end, that's always a good thing."

“I just hope I can wrap this up in a few days, so I can come home to you guys.” Of course Adora had lived away from her moms and Razz before, during college and such, but she was really missing them right now. Their teasing aside, they were a great support system.

“You’ve got this, Adora,” Mara reassured her. “You’re gonna do great. How could Catra say no to you?”

Adora thought back to her earlier conversation with Catra. Hordak was right, there *was* a lot of sentimentality involved here. Catra could very easily refuse to sell.

Could Adora even blame her?

Chapter End Notes

headcanoning horse girl adora because why not

next update: dec 1

Skating

Chapter Summary

Catra opens up to Adora about her past. But a key player from Adora's own past hasn't had the last word yet.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra and Adora hadn’t spoken since the former snapped at her the evening prior. Adora understood her frustration—she really did—but at some point, they needed to have a serious talk about the logistics of this transaction. By now, Adora would’ve loved to start price negotiations; Hordak really had downplayed how uninterested Catra was in selling the property. Adora already felt behind the curve just two days into this whole mess. Of course, as if he had read her mind, Hordak’s phone call coincided with that thought. Adora groaned as she picked up her phone.

“Hello, Adora. You’ve been radio-silent. Have you gotten our stubborn farmer to sell the property yet?” Hordak sounded utterly no-nonsense, so Adora started to panic. The answer was a hard “no”.

“Well, you see…” Adora stammered, trying to think of a way to cover her ass. “It’s been—”

“Please, I’m only giving you a hard time. It’s only the fourteenth of December, and you’ve been given twelve days to seal this deal. You have time.”

“Oh. Right.” Adora gulped, thankful that Hordak wasn’t calling her to scold her. But maybe that sentiment was premature.

“Still, though, I’m trusting that you can wrap up this project in a timely manner,” Hordak pressed on. “I won’t mince words. I could have sent Double Trouble or one of your other colleagues, but I

sent you, Adora. Don't forget that an executive position is on the line."

Okay, that sort of sounds like a threat, Adora worried. *Like he said, it's only been a few days. I'm not a magician.* "Of course, Hordak. I won't disappoint you," Adora tried to make her voice sound sugary, an inflection she always used when pretending everything was fine.

"Thank you, Adora. Well, how are things in Bright Moon? And what progress have you made with Ms. Driluth?"

"Bright Moon is quaint, and definitely small, but it's got spirit. I think it's a good place for this development project. And, well, Catra's farm seems to be in a lot of financial trouble. I don't see why I can't convince her that selling it would be a lot smarter than keeping it. It's just going to take a bit more time. I'm actually staying on her farm right now, by the way, which makes things… interesting." Adora tried not to be edgy with Hordak, but she still couldn't believe that he had failed to secure an inn reservation for her.

"Oh, yes… My secretary had told me that the inn was full, but I forgot to pass that news along. My apologies."

"No problem at all," Adora replied through gritted teeth. "Catra has been hospitable enough." An embellishment of the truth, but Adora wasn't going to get into that now.

"Glad to hear it. Well, I'll let you get back to it, Adora. I hope to see you back at the office before Christmas."

"Thank you, Hordak. I know I will be." Adora signed off the call.

Remember why you're doing this, Adora reminded herself, taking a deep breath and rubbing her temples. Essentially, all she had to do was get Catra to sign some papers, and then she'd be back in Manhattan (with a promotion) before she knew it. Of course, that description of her task made it sound a lot easier than it was, considering Catra was stubborn as a mule.

Speaking of which, Adora knew she had to clear the air with Catra. She put on her winter hat and gloves and walked over to the main house, hurrying to avoid bearing the frigid temperatures for too long. The door was open, so Adora called out to Catra. No response; she wasn't in right now. Her truck was in the driveway, though, so she was probably still on the farm. Adora decided to look for her elsewhere on the property. First, she checked the horse stables, and also stopped to pet Swift Wind for a minute. No sign of Catra, so she moved on. Next, she walked through the blocks of trees, seeing if perhaps Catra was tending to them. However, she wasn't sure how much progress she had made, since they all looked relatively similar.

Fifteen minutes passed, and Adora still hadn't found Catra yet. She was beginning to give up when she stumbled upon a toolshed towards the back of the property. Catra hadn't shown her this area on the tour, strangely. Behind the shed was a small frozen pond, upon which Catra was… skillfully figure skating? It wasn't Olympic-level, per se, but the farmer looked like she actually knew what she was doing. Adora couldn't help but admire Catra's twists and turns, how gracefully her skate grazed the ice, and how her hair flew wildly every time she moved.

"Catra!" Adora called out, still several yards away from the pond. Catra heard her, and met Adora at the edge of the pond. "Wow. You skate *really* well."

Catra, maintaining humility, played it off. "I'm all right. A bit rusty, really. And now I'm kind of embarrassed that you caught me skating."

"What, it doesn't fit your image?" Catra furrowed her brows at Adora, but there was a glint in her eyes indicating that it was in jest. Adora cleared her throat, then continued, "Anyway, I actually came here to talk to you. I wanted to... I-I just think things have been a little tense…" She tried to sound cool, calm, and collected, but it wasn't quite working.

"Yeah." Catra's face, already flushed by the cold, turned rosier. She looked down at her skates.

"Can we talk? You and me, face to face? We've got to have the conversation about selling at some point. I know it's hard, and I appreciate that—"

"Okay, okay, I'll talk," Catra gave in, putting up a hand. "First, though, I'm going to finish skating, as I was doing before you interrupted me. Scorpia left her skates in the toolshed again, so if they fit, you can join me. Unless you happened to bring your own skates."

"Uh… All right," Adora agreed. "I don't own any, but I'll go check the shed." Ice skating with Catra definitely wasn't what Adora had envisioned for this trip, but figured she might as well do it. (If only to compensate for last night's tiff.) Plus, Catra seemed to be in a good mood for once, and Adora wasn't going to ruffle any feathers.

It was hard to find the skates at first, as the shed was dark and mildly dusty. However, some light poured in from the slats on the side of the shed, so Adora could see the skates resting on a shelf. Luckily, they were the right size. Adora went back to the pond and replaced her boots with the white figure skates.

Catra held out her hand to help Adora onto the pond, and she hesitantly grabbed onto it. It was weird to think she was holding hands with Catra, even if only for a second. *Stop being weird, Adora,* she subtly shook her head as if to scold herself. When the blade of her skate made contact with the ice, she almost fell backwards, but Catra swept in and placed a hand on Adora's back, keeping her upright. Their faces were only inches apart. Adora's body froze for a moment, but she regained her composure and used Catra's shoulders to right her balance. Gently, Catra let go of her waist.

"Whoa, Adora, are you okay?" Catra didn't use any nicknames, which shocked Adora. Usually, she would have had to deal with an

onslaught of snark. But Catra sounded genuinely concerned.

Adora felt quite unstable on the ice, and was keenly aware of how close Catra was to her, but she managed a slight nod and put a foot of distance between them. She didn't want to be unprofessional, especially only on the third day of her stay. "Yeah, I'm good. That would have been a nasty fall, so… thank you. By the way, this ice is completely frozen, right?"

"No, I just like to skate on thin ice for fun," Catra deadpanned. Adora didn't get the joke at first, and gaped at Catra. Catra chuckled, breaking her sarcasm, "Oh, come on. It's frozen solid. It gets so cold here in the winter, there's no chance of it melting."

"Oh. I just wanted to make sure." Adora shyly started to skate forwards, but had to put her arms out for balance. "I'm not a good skater, by the way. I mean, I used to skate at Rockefeller when I was a kid, but I always used to topple over then, too. I was so clumsy, my moms had to patch up quite a few scrapes."

"Huh. That's funny, you always struck me as a jock. But, anyway… I *guess*, if you *really* want, I can teach you a bit," Catra proposed playfully.

She held out her hand to Adora again, whose heart started to flutter. *No. Bad Adora. Don't think about Catra that way.* "Um, teach me to skate r-right now?"

"No better time than the present."

Oh, what the hell. "Fine, why not?" Adora's palm touched Catra's through their gloves, and the latter slowly started to skate backwards, taking Adora with her across the ice. Adora was terrified of falling over again, so she shut her eyes and let Catra take the lead. Feeling herself push against the wind was a lot more fun when she wasn't looking down at the slippery ice.

"You have to open your eyes to skate, you know," Catra quipped once they had skated the length of the pond. "All right, now you

try on your own. Remember, one foot at a time, and point your toes inward if you need to come to a stop."

"Got it." Adora heeded Catra's advice, using her right foot to push off and then gliding once she gained some momentum. As she reached the center of the pond, she felt like she had gotten the hang of it; she confidently used her left foot to propel her forward… Then, she fell on her butt. *That's gonna be sore tomorrow,* she winced, the ice uncomfortably palpable through her pants. *I'm not as young as I used to be.*

Catra heartily guffawed at the sight, but immediately skated over to check on Adora. She extended her arm to the businesswoman, who gratefully used it to stand up again. "Not a bad start. But I think the goal is to stay upright. On two feet. At the same time."

"Easier said than done." Adora felt a grin spread across her face. For some reason, being around Catra made her feel warm, even in the glacial weather. Then again, Catra also drove her crazy sometimes. Adora never knew which one it was going to be.

"Don't worry, I won't be too hard on you. I've probably had more practice than you, anyway, so it's not fair. My dad and I used to skate out here all the time." Catra paused, but Adora was still listening attentively. "He, um, died when I was ten, but I have a lot of great memories of him. Especially around Christmastime. He taught me to skate, and more importantly, how to farm. Well, as much as you can teach a ten year-old. Anyway, it's just… after he died, I didn't really get to skate anymore."

"Why not?"

"Shadow Weaver wouldn't let me do it after he died. I think she hated seeing me happy, honestly. She said that my time would be better spent helping out on the farm or cleaning the house. Or she'd tell me I was a terrible skater and that it was a waste of time. Still, though, that's probably not even in the top thirty worst things she said to me throughout my childhood."

Adora noticed Catra's clenched fist, and put her palm on Catra's shoulder to comfort her. "I'm sorry, Catra. You didn't deserve to be treated like that. No one does."

Slowly, Catra's fist loosened. Her gold and blue eyes met Adora's, and she could sense her genuine appreciation. "A couple therapists later, I know that now. But that means a lot, Adora. Thank you."

"Of course." The two of them were standing on the ice, and Adora awkwardly put her hands in her pockets, not quite knowing what to say. "I don't want to be your enemy, you know."

"Yeah, I know," Catra pushed air out of her nose, but Adora could tell that Catra truly wasn't angry at her. "Do you want to go inside? I've been out here for a while, and I'm freezing. We can talk business over hot chocolate."

Adora beamed at the farmer. "I thought you'd never ask."

"One more thing, though," Catra added with a mischievous glint in her eyes, "Race me to the edge of the pond. Three, two, one, go!" She counted the numbers off quickly, then whizzed away, leaving Adora behind her.

"Hey, not fair!" Adora started after her. "You got a head start."

Catra, who had already reached the finish line, smirked devilishly as Adora caught up to her. "My farm, my rules, princess."

Before Catra prepared their hot cocoa from scratch, she put the *Charlie Brown Christmas* vinyl on the record player that sat in the living room. Even Adora, self-proclaimed Christmas hater, had to admit she loved that soundtrack. (The *Charlie Brown* Christmas special was a staple of Adora's childhood, and her moms still watched it each year.) Once their drinks were ready, Catra invited Adora to sit down on a chair in the living room. An ample fir, upon which copious ornaments hung, was stationed in front of the window. Adora smiled at the custom-made ornaments with

pictures of Melog on the front, but she also noticed a lot of vintage-looking ornaments too. Adora wondered if Catra had personally collected all of them, or if any of them were passed down from her father.

"So, a mall, huh?" Catra sighed between sips of cocoa. She was holding a faded *Bright Moon Christmas Carnival 2007* mug with a red knit mug cozy.

"That seems to be the plan," Adora confirmed, not making eye contact with Catra. "They can do a lot with this land. I-if that's what you want, of course," she immediately added. After yesterday's blunder, Adora resolved that she would be much more sensitive when talking to Catra about these things.

"It's not really about what I want anymore. It's more about what I have to do." Catra paused for a moment, playing with the stitches on her mug cozy. "This life is… a lot of work, with not much profit. I guess I've just always thought that loving my job would be enough. And I really can't imagine being anything *but* a Christmas tree farmer, but maybe I'll have to. I don't know."

"Maybe I'm supposed to convince you to sell the farm, but at the end of the day, it's your choice. I can't make the decision for you. The only thing I'm going to say is that if you sell the farm, you'll be able to live comfortably for a while. The property is worth a lot of money."

"So, all I have to do is sign some papers and my life will change for the better?" It wasn't clear if Catra was being facetious or not.

"In short, yes," Adora shrugged, thumbing the corner of the Manila folder on her lap which contained the paperwork in question. She had retrieved it before sitting down with Catra, but she doubted it would be used today. No harm in hoping, though. "I mean, it's a little more nuanced than that, but you get the gist."

Catra vigorously stirred a spoon in her hot chocolate, deep in thought. Finally, she responded. "All right. I still need a little bit

more time to think about it, but… you've got me listening. I'll *consider* selling the farm so you can build your mall, or whatever."

"Really?" Adora's eyes nearly bugged out of her skull. She hadn't expected Catra to be receptive whatsoever.

"Yeah. But, again, I want to think about it for a few more days. I know you probably want to hightail it out of Bright Moon as soon as possible and get back to New York, though, so… I'm sorry to delay you."

"Actually…" Adora considered the events of the last two days. Small towns usually weren't her thing, but Bright Moon wasn't so bad. "It might surprise you to hear that I kind of like it here. It's more charming than I thought it would be." *And* you're *more charming than I thought you'd be,* Adora didn't say.

"Wow, I wasn't expecting that, princess. Well, how could you *not* like it here when the company's so great?" Catra teased. "I mean, I hear the farmer you're staying with even makes you hot chocolate. That has to count for something, right?"

"Ha, ha," Adora rolled her eyes. "But, seriously, thank you for letting me stay on this farm, even if you really didn't want to. I don't even know where I would have gone."

"In all fairness, Scorpia kind of made that choice for me." Catra played with her hair, which she had since put into a messy ponytail. Clearly, she wasn't good at handling gratitude.

"Yeah, but you could have said no. It's your farm," Adora reaffirmed, resting her elbows on the table. "I won't let you wriggle out of this one."

The two of them had a staring contest until Catra finally gave in. "Agh, okay. You're… you're welcome." Catra sighed, "Also, you should know that I usually don't talk so much about my family stuff like I did today. I'm not trying to be weird, or anything. My closest friends know all about it, but I shouldn't have dumped it on someone I've only known for—"

“Catra. It’s totally fine.” Adora reassuringly smiled at her. “I really don’t mind. It’s good to express your feelings, you know?”

“I guess I feel like I should move on from everything that’s happened to me. But I can’t. I just feel…”

“Stuck?” Adora finished as Catra said it. The two shared a knowing glance. “I’m familiar with the feeling. I’ve been having kind of a rough year, and I get the sense that everyone around me wants me to move on too. Like they’re tired of my moping. Believe me, that’s all I want, but it’s not easy.”

Catra seemed to be wondering what struggles Adora was referencing, but she didn’t overstep. She simply nodded in agreement. “People just don’t get it.”

There was a comfortable silence as they finished their drinks, only broken by Adora’s cell phone buzzing on the wooden table after a few minutes. She picked up the phone, thinking nothing of it, but her stomach dropped when she saw the notification on the screen. Nothing could have prepared her for the name attached to it.

Huntara Rose

1 New Text Message

Chapter End Notes

lesbians. that's it, that's the note

(thanks for reading, if you're here!)

next update: dec 4

The Ghost of Christmas Past

Chapter Summary

> Adora debates how she should respond to Huntara's text. Meanwhile, she starts to spend more time with Catra, coming to terms with the fact that her feelings aren't completely platonic.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's going to get married.

Everything has been leading up to this day. She told her moms about it last week, and they cheered and hugged her when they saw the engagement ring. The same ring she has in her pocket right now. Thankfully, she's planned it all to a tee. It's Christmas Eve, and she's going to propose to Huntara after dinner. On Christmas, they'll go to Adora's moms' house to celebrate the holiday as fiancées. Adora is dressed up for the occasion, in a sparkly black dress, with her hair down and red on her lips. It's going to be one of the most important moments of her life, save for the actual wedding. And she can't stop thinking about how it'll feel to walk down the aisle towards Huntara, who will be there staring lovingly at her.

But when Huntara comes in the door that day and kisses her on the cheek, something is wrong. She's stiff when Adora embraces her. She won't look at Adora for long; she just glances and then makes a point of directing her attention elsewhere. If Adora didn't know better, she'd say Huntara looks guilty. But Adora knows she's just reading too far into things because she's nervous to propose. She's been with Huntara for three and a half years, and she knows that her girlfriend loves her more than anything.

Adora and Huntara are in the middle of frosting some Christmas sugar cookies when Huntara has to excuse herself from the room.

She's been taciturn the whole time… something is *wrong. Adora checks on her, and her heart sinks when she notices Huntara sitting, in tears, on the bed. Her head is in her hands. Adora goes to sit down next to her, wondering if anything happened to elicit her crying, but the reason is nothing she would've ever expected.*

"I can't do this anymore." Huntara won't look at Adora, and she still doesn't fully know where this is going. What it means. Adora shakes her head in confusion, but Huntara repeats herself. "No, Adora, I mean it. I-I'm not cut out for this."

"Cut out for what *?" Adora's eyes are beginning to well up. Huntara's words are vague, but Adora is aware of what's happening now. That, in some way, this is the end for them. "Huntara—"*

"I saw the ring in the drawer yesterday. When I was looking for my watch. I know you were going to propose soon. God, Adora, I… I love you, but I just can't commit like this. I'm so sorry." "Y-You found the ring?" Adora feels her stomach drop. Huntara doesn't want to marry her. How had she misjudged their relationship so badly? Now that she's thinking about it, there were moments when Huntara seemed… hesitant. Tentative. But Adora had shrugged them off, and that was undeniably a mistake.

"None of this is your fault, it's just… I'm not ready for marriage. I don't know if I ever will be. My parents weren't exactly a great example. But you do want to get married, and I don't think any amount of time is going to get us on the same page." Huntara sounds so guilty, but also so matter-of-fact, and Adora doesn't know whether to cry or scream. She wants to do both, but only sits frozen next to Huntara. This wasn't what was supposed to happen today. They were going to be… She can't even think of the word. Engaged. *She feels a lump in her throat as she imagines having to tell Mara and Hope that Huntara said no. But that's not even accurate, because Adora never got to ask.*

Adora just nods, and at some point, Huntara leaves the apartment. It's all a blur, though, and she doesn't know exactly

how or when she left. All she can clearly sense is the TV, blaring some feel-good Christmas romcom.

Adora wants to smash the screen.

Adora distinctly felt the weight of her phone in her back pocket, almost as if Huntara's message was tangible. Either way, it was a nuisance, and she threw her phone onto her bed in frustration. Eventually, she ended up smashing her face into the pillows, trying to drown out the world. It didn't work, of course, because the issue still remained: she hadn't answered Huntara yet. For the millionth time, she picked up her phone, opened the Messages app, and read her text again.

Huntara:

Hey Adora, I hope you're doing well. I guess I've just been thinking about you a lot lately. My worldview has changed a lot in the last year, including how I feel about marriage. I'll just say it, leaving you was one of the biggest mistakes of my life. If you want to have a conversation, I'd love to talk to you, face to face. Happy holidays, Huntara xx

Adora wrinkled her nose at the text's closer: "happy holidays". Ironic, wasn't it, since Huntara breaking up with her was most of the reason she started hating Christmas. The holidays really weren't all that happy for Adora anymore.

She couldn't lie, though. Something about Huntara reaching out to her tugged at her heartstrings. Maybe it was the inherent emotional impact of it all. Huntara was practically asking Adora to take her back—which, a year ago, Adora would have done in a heartbeat. They once had a great thing, that was true. But still, Huntara hurt Adora by leaving, and Adora didn't think she could ever trust her again.

The question of how to respond lingered in Adora's mind. She wondered if she should even answer in the first place. At Catra's dining room table that morning, while waiting for breakfast to be served, she had her gaze fixed on the text. She had overanalyzed every single letter by this point. Maybe it was unhealthy to ruminate like this, but she couldn't stop.

Adora noticed that Catra kept glancing at her phone screen as she refilled their coffee cups, but Catra didn't say anything. she probably hadn't seen what the message said, although she did look miffed at something. Adora was too preoccupied with everything to ask what it was.

"I was thinking maybe we could take the horses for a ride today," Catra suggested while they ate. It seemed like her slight bad mood had dissipated by now. "They could use it, actually. You can go with Swift Wind, since he likes you."

"Wait, really? That'd be so much fun," Adora concurred, clasping her hands together in excitement. "I haven't been on a horse since I was a kid, but I know the basics. Like, saying 'whoa' or whatever when you want them to stop."

"Yeah, 'whoa or whatever,'" Catra smirked. "We can go after breakfast."

The two of them walked to the stables together after they had finished eating. It was cold, but not too frosty, so the weather was all right for riding. Then, Catra gathered all of the riding equipment. First, she saddled Swift Wind and took care to tighten the cinch. Then, she did the same for her horse, Clawdeen.

Adora raised an eyebrow at the horse's name tag. "Why is your horse named… Clawdeen?"

Catra chuckled and patted the horse's side. "Clawdeen has always had the heart of a lion. Brave and strong. That's why I named her that, when I was younger. I-I know it's kind of dumb."

"It's not dumb, it's cute," Adora smiled. "We all named our pets something like that as kids."

"Sounds like *you* have an embarrassing example," Catra remarked, brushing through Swift Wind's mane.

"I sort of named my dog Kowl when I was six."

Catra cocked her head in puzzlement. "Kowl? What does that…"

"It's because he had a lot of splotches on his fur, so I thought he looked like a cow. But he also howled a lot when we first got him, so I just combined the two. Cow and howl. Also, I couldn't really spell, so 'Kowl' was spelled with a 'K.'"

"Shouldn't have told me that. It's just too easy to start teasing you about it now," Catra joked, warranting an eye roll from Adora. "Just kidding. That's actually adorable."

"My moms definitely thought so," Adora replied. "They won't let me forget about it, either. Even though Kowl is in dog heaven, rest his soul. He was a good boy, though."

"Rest in peace, Kowl," Catra put her hand to her heart. She checked the horses and their equipment one last time, then turned to Adora. "All right, are we ready to go, or what? Swift Wind's chomping at the bit here."

Adora eagerly nodded, and Catra led Swift Wind out of the stall by his bridle. With Catra's help, Adora stepped into the stirrups, then swung her leg over so that she was balanced on the horse. She grabbed Swift Wind's reins, and gently petted his shiny coat. Catra then mounted Clawdeen with ease, and started to go forward. Adora used the reins to lead Swift Wind behind them.

Catra and Adora didn't talk much as they rode their respective horses around the property, as it was somewhat difficult for them to hear each other when Catra was a few yards ahead. But Adora enjoyed being in her company. It was strange, how much they had been at odds at first, and now Adora was simply… happy to

be in Catra's presence. She knew what that meant by now, and she wasn't going to pretend that feelings for Catra hadn't arisen. Still, though, she wasn't going to act on them. That would be unprofessional, and pointless. Catra lived a life completely different from Adora's—simple, yes, but that was nice at times. Adora, in all the rush of her high-powered corporate career, could never be a part of that. She just had to remind herself that her job in Manhattan was everything she had been working for, everything she had ever wanted. She'd see that when she returned home.

Much of the existing snow on the ground had melted away, but it began to slowly yet steadily fall while Adora and Catra were out riding. They had covered a lot of the farm at that point, so they decided to call it a day and return to the stable.

Catra dismounted Clawdeen with ease, but Adora was having a bit more trouble. She wasn't as accustomed to this as Catra was. She slid her foot into the stirrup, but something didn't feel right. It began to wobble, and she felt herself losing her balance and falling to the ground. Her right hand was the first thing to break her fall.

"Adora!" Catra noticed what had happened and ran to her without a second thought. Adora groaned on the ground; nothing was broken, but it wasn't a fun feeling. "Are you—"

"I'm… Just help me up, please," Adora grunted, and Catra obliged. Adora was kind of mortified by the fact that this had happened twice. Was she really that clumsy?

"I'm getting a strange sense of déjà vu," Catra quipped, echoing Adora's thoughts. "I'm not letting you step outside unless you're covered in bubble wrap."

"I'm not *that* bad," Adora jumped to her own defense, but realized Catra was kind of right. "Well, maybe I am." She went to dust herself off, but first realized that her hand had been scraped by a twig. It was bleeding slightly.

“Hold on, let me see that,” Catra took Adora’s hand and examined the cut. “I don’t want that to get infected. I’ll bandage it inside.”

“No, no, I can do that myself,” Adora waved her off. Catra *literally tending to her wounds* was kind of too much for Adora to handle right now. Especially since she had just admitted to herself that she had feelings for Catra.

“Come on. You don’t even know where I keep the bandages or the antiseptic. Let me do it, tough guy.”

Adora sighed deeply, giving in. She’d just have to keep her feelings under wraps. “Okay, fine. I appreciate it.”

“It’s good as new.” Catra smoothed a bandage over the skin of Adora’s hand. The wound initially stung a bit from the antiseptic, but the pain was gradually lessening. “Just don’t make me kiss the boo-boo or anything. I'm not partial to that brand of sappiness.”

“I agree. Thank you, though.” Adora then put her head in her hands, flustered. “I guess the secret is out… I’m ridiculously clumsy.”

“There are worse things to be.” Catra put the antiseptic back in the medicine cabinet. She paused for a moment, thinking about something, then cleared her throat. “Uh, by the way… I’m not trying to pry, but whose text did you keep staring at? During breakfast?”

Adora was embarrassed at being caught obsessing over Huntara’s text. “Um, her name’s Huntara.” She wasn’t sure how much more she wanted to elaborate on that.

“So, um… is Huntara your…” Catra lingered on each word, hesitant.

“My what?” Adora asked, guessing she already knew what Catra was going to say.

"Girlfriend." Catra looked down at her combat boots. Adora was quiet, caught off guard by the question, and Catra immediately backtracked. "Sorry, forget I asked. You don't have to tell me."

"No, no, it's fine. We're not… dating anymore. She broke up with me last year." Adora wondered why Catra wanted to know who she was dating. She added, without being prompted, "I'm not dating anyone right now, actually."
"Breakups are always rough. I'm sorry that happened, Adora." Catra's tone of voice was unreadable. She sounded genuine, but also not.

"Yeah, it *was* rough…" Adora was unsure of what to say after that.

Catra continued, "I'm not dating anyone either. I recently got out of this on-and-off thing a few months ago. Lonnie's great, but I really want something more out of my relationships, you know?"

"I understand that," Adora answered truthfully, since her last relationship had ended over a disagreement about commitment. To put it lightly. But the more Adora thought about that now, the less she twinged with heartbreak. She truly didn't want Huntara back anymore, even if she once yearned for that. "Can you excuse me for a sec?" Catra nodded, and Adora went into the living room and sat on the recliner. Then she pulled out her phone and started drafting a text.

Adora:

I'm doing well, and I hope you are too. I don't think I'm open to talking, though. Have a happy and safe holiday season, Adora

With a swift motion of her finger, she pressed "send".

Chapter End Notes

i really appreciate all of the support for this fic so far!

this chapter was a bit shorter but chapter 5 is going to be longer to make up for it :)

next update: dec 8

The Fire Is So Delightful

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia wants to win Perfuma's affections, so she convinces Catra to host a romantic bonfire at the farm—the perfect atmosphere for falling in love. But Scorpia and Perfuma aren't the only ones who are growing closer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

On Adora's fifth day in Bright Moon, Scorpia paid a visit to Driluth Farms. Adora was in the living room, checking some emails for work on her laptop, with Melog curled up on her lap. Meanwhile, Scorpia and Catra were having a long discussion in the kitchen. Adora couldn't hear much, but from the sound of it, an enlivened Scorpia was talking Catra's ear off. When Adora went to the sink to refill her glass of water, she caught some of the conversation.

"Catra, Perfuma actually said 'hi' to me at the grocery store. She *knows my name*. Can you believe it?" Scorpia squealed, jumping around. "That's why I've got to test the waters, and see if she likes me, but I'm too nervous to just hang out with her alone. Hang on… Ooh, we should all have a bonfire at the farm! That'd be so romantic."

Catra sighed, leaning against the counter. "...A bonfire? Here? Couldn't we do something at your place?"

"I live in an apartment, silly. I can't do a bonfire. But here, it'd be perfect!" Scorpia chirped. "We can invite Entrapta, too. And of course Adora will be there," she added, turning to the businesswoman. Adora gave her a slight nod in acknowledgement.

"I appreciate that you want me to be your wingwoman, but can't you make a move on your own?" Catra shrugged. "Go and ask

Perfuma on a date, or something. What's the worst that could happen?"

"Uh, the worst that could happen is that she could say 'no' because I made a fool of myself by blathering on for too long. Catra, you know I don't have enough game to just *make a move* on Perfuma," Scorpia whined, gesturing wildly for emphasis. "But in a group setting—a romantic winter bonfire, no less—it'd be much easier. I need you to help me with this, Catra. Pretty, pretty please?" Scorpia made puppy-dog eyes at her friend.

"Oh, all right," Catra sighed, then was immediately enveloped in a bear hug from Scorpia. "Oof—okay, that's a little tight." Scorpia quickly let go and stepped back, but her face was lit up like a Christmas tree. She was clearly grateful.

"Hey, as long as we're having a little get-together… Can we invite Bow and Glimmer, too?" Adora asked them. She thought they seemed really cool, but also, there was a *sliiiiight* possibility that she wanted to hear more stories from the couple about Catra's rock band days.

"The more, the merrier," Scorpia affirmed. "They're friends with Perfuma, so that works. Since she's the art teacher at Bright Moon High School, she knows Bow pretty well."

"I *suppose* I can put up with Sparkles for a few hours," Catra muttered. Adora mouthed a *thank you* to her. She suspected that Catra's grievances with Glimmer weren't all that serious, anyway. One could only hold on to high school drama for so long.

"All right, it's settled. How about 8?" Scorpia suggested. "I'll send out a text to everyone who's coming right now. Except for you two, because obviously you already know," she giggled nervously. From the sound of it, her mind was going a mile a minute.

"Okay, that works for me," Catra replied, seeming a bit exasperated but overall agreeable. "We can start getting the house ready this afternoon."

"Thanks again, Catra. I need to go get *myself* ready now, so I'm gonna head out." Scorpia waved goodbye, and was soon out the door.

"The bonfire isn't for hours. How much time does she need?" Adora chuckled once Scorpia was gone.

"A lot, I guess. She really likes Perfuma," Catra explained. "She's been working up the courage to do this for months. I'm glad she's finally getting it over with, even if it means I have to host a gathering with such short notice."

"Hey, I'm happy to help out," Adora offered. "I can go into town and pick up some food. And wine."

"You're a lifesaver. Make sure to get some ingredients for s'mores, by the way. If I have to host a bonfire, I'm gonna do it right."

"You got it." Adora gave her a thumbs up. She ripped a page from one of her notebooks and started scribbling down a shopping list, checking it with Catra before she left. The list had everything they needed, so she drove her car into downtown Bright Moon and stopped at the local grocery store. She picked up some spinach and artichoke dip and chips, for the guests to enjoy inside the house before the bonfire. She also picked up a few bottles of red wine. Finally, she got marshmallows, chocolate, and graham crackers, per Catra's request to make s'mores.

Catra was shoveling snow off her front porch when Adora returned with the groceries. She immediately tried to fish some cash out of her wallet to compensate for what Adora spent, but was refused. "You don't need to give me anything, Catra. The fact that you're letting me stay in your guest house is enough."

"If you say so." Catra put her wallet in the back pocket of her jeans. "You're not so bad for a houseguest, though."

Adora blushed profusely. "You're not a bad hostess." Catra smirked at her and continued shoveling . *Why are we flirting with each other?* Adora felt her face grow hotter, and hoped Catra would

attribute its redness to the frigid temperature. She decided to bring the groceries inside before she said anything too bold. Again, professionalism was still very much a priority for her. She doubted Hordak would take too kindly to any sort of romantic relationship between Adora and Catra, if one existed—which it didn't, of course. (Then again, maybe he'd appreciate it, if it meant the firm got Catra's property. He was a confusing man.) Adora was confident that she and Catra could keep their relationship strictly to business, though.

Speaking of relationships, Huntara hadn't answered Adora's last text yet. It seemed like she wouldn't answer it at all. Adora hoped this meant that Huntara was ready to move on, too. Maybe Adora wasn't ready to jump back into the Christmas frenzy she once relished in, but she was tired of this breakup's influence over her life. She didn't want it to be dragged out any longer than it needed to. It was a shame that things couldn't have worked out between them, but, more and more, Adora was starting to feel like they were never meant to work out. There were other fish in the sea. If Adora's feelings towards a certain farmer had anything to do with that realization, so be it.

As the time of the bonfire drew near, Catra enlisted Adora to help her carry stacks of wood outside to the fire pit, which was located just behind the main house. She also tasked Adora with finding tinder and kindling. The twinges of an orange and pink sunset were starting to emerge, but there was still plenty of light outside, so both of them were able to see what they were doing.

"How are we going to make a fire when there's all of this snow?" Adora inquired, looking down at the several inches that had fallen overnight.

"You're clearly underestimating my fire-building abilities," Catra scoffed playfully, laying some wood in the fire pit. "As long as the wood is dry, it should be fine. Actually, it's even more fun when there's snow. I like a challenge."

Adora took a few minutes to look around for small sticks and fallen pine needles, mainly finding them scattered a few feet away from the large trees. She was able to gather a large bundle, and handed them to Catra. She gingerly arranged them in the fire pit, and dusted her hands off when she was satisfied.

"I'll get the fire going just before everyone gets here," Catra explained. "Don't want it to burn out."

"That makes sense." Adora stood back, examining the scene. "Do you have any chairs to put out so we can all sit?"

"Oh, good thinking," Catra snapped her fingers. "I've probably got enough chairs in the shed. If I don't, we'll just use the ones from the porch, too." Within a few minutes, they had placed seven chairs around the fire. "I think we're ready for our guests."

"We've done well," Adora nodded at Catra, both sharing a smile. "What now? We've got a ton of time."

Catra paused for a moment, but then she tented and fluttered her fingers as if she had just concocted some grand scheme. Adora practically saw the lightbulb go on above her head. Catra knelt down to the snow and gathered it into her hands, packing it into a snowball. Slowly, she looked up at Adora. "I have a few ideas. Can't put all of this snow to waste." As she stood up, she extended her arm and pressed the snowball into Adora's shoulder.

"Oh, you're bad," Adora laughed, white powdery snow exploding on her jacket. "I'm gonna get you for that one." She hastily scraped some snow together and threw it at Catra in retaliation. It landed in her hair, making the strands wet.

"You're on, princess," Catra grinned, already forming and promptly lobbing another snowball. This one narrowly missed Adora, who ran a few yards away to stockpile some snowballs of her own. This preparative strategy seemed to work better for her, and for a while, she seemed to be decisively winning the snowball fight. Catra preferred to launch her snow-attack from a closer distance,

though, working more on impulse. After all, she was able to assemble snowballs in a freakishly fast manner.

However, Adora consistently dodged Catra's onslaught of snowballs, defending herself by running from them. "I'm not such a prissy city girl now, am I?" Adora shouted playfully.

"You can't keep running, Adora," Catra teased in a sing-songy way. "Come on, face the wrath of the snowball master!"

Adora cackled, throwing her head back. "You did *not* just call yourself the snowball master. Being cheesy is my th—"

In the midst of her laughter, Adora didn't notice Catra coming towards her, hurling a snowball point-blank into her side. Either the surprise of Catra's charge caught Adora off balance or Catra had more momentum than she anticipated, because suddenly the two of them were falling to the ground. As Adora landed first, the snow cushioned her, but she was also hit by the impact of Catra falling on top of her. However, the strength of the impact was the last thing on her mind right now, because… *Catra was on top of her.* Catra's legs straddled Adora's, their faces only inches apart. Adora could see now how soft Catra's lips looked, and desperately wanted to kiss them. She should have moved, but she couldn't. The power of Catra's heterochromatic eyes burning into Adora's was simultaneously enough to melt her and freeze her in place. *Damn.* Adora prayed that Catra couldn't hear her heart pounding through her jacket, because its sound was surely thundering. In this moment, she knew how screwed she was. She knew how badly she wanted Catra.

"We have to stop meeting like this," Catra breathed, not taking her gaze off Adora. "I meant what I said."

"What?" Adora whispered, still trying to catch her breath. This was almost too much to handle.

"I'm not letting you outside without bubble wrap anymore." Adora couldn't help but smile at Catra's repartée.

Neither of them had made any effort to move away from the other. Adora's head still rested in the snow, clumps of it getting inside the hood of her jacket. All she wanted was to be with Catra, to run her hands through her hair. Professional implications be damned. And maybe Catra wanted it too, because Adora could have sworn that Catra's face was inching closer and closer and—

"There you guys are, I've been looking for you for ages—" Scorpia loudly trudged through the snow. "Oh. Did I… ahem, interrupt something?" She instantly turned away and started whistling, trying to pretend she had seen nothing. She wasn't being very subtle about it, though.

Catra stood up, dusting off her jeans which had been wet by the snow. "No, nope, you're all good. Did you need something, Scorpia?" Catra was flustered at first but quickly regained her composure. She also helped Adora up from the ground, but wouldn't quite look at her. Adora wondered what that indicated about Catra's feelings.

"I was just wondering if you had anywhere I could put this." Scorpia produced a plant with white berries from her bag, tied with a red ribbon.

Adora squinted her eyes at the plant. "Is that mistletoe?"

"It sure is," Scorpia smiled proudly. "And sometime tonight, Perfuma and I are going to somehow find ourselves underneath it. If she kisses me on the lips, and not on the cheek, then I can finally be sure that she likes me."

"Ah, yes. The old mistletoe trick. Can I tell you how much I *don't* recommend you use that as your litmus test for Perfuma's attraction?" Catra snorted. Scorpia looked down sheepishly. "Also, we can't put that inside, because mistletoe is toxic to pets. All you have to do is be honest and open with Perfuma, you don't need mistletoe for that."

"I could say the same to you," Scorpia muttered, then covered it with a cough. It didn't go unnoticed by Adora. *Okay, so she definitely thinks Catra likes me,* Adora thought.

Scorpia continued, "Come on, Catra, it's Christmastime. Can't I at least hang it somewhere on the back porch?"

Catra held out her hand, and Scorpia placed the mistletoe in it. "I'll hang it before Perfuma gets here. But remember what I said. You've got this, Scorpia."

Scorpia patted Catra on the shoulder. "Thanks, Catra. Oh, man, I'm getting nervous. I'll be inside if anyone needs me." She trudged through the snow and went through the back door of Catra's house.

Catra gave Adora a knowing glance. "It's going to be an interesting night," she remarked, arms crossed. "Sorry I knocked you over, by the way. The blame for that one is kind of on me." If their *moment* had riled her up at all, her demeanor didn't betray her. She was cool as a cucumber.

Maybe she doesn't like me then, Adora winced, her heart sinking. *But I guess it won't ever matter, anyway.* She brushed off Catra's comment, "Don't worry, it's all good. I'm not hurt, or anything. You just got a little bit too passionate about that snowball fight."

Catra gave her a lopsided grin. "Happens to the best of us. Come on, let's get inside before we freeze out here."

Ironically, Perfuma was the last guest to arrive at Driluth Farms for the gathering. Scorpia panicked all the while—really, if the others didn't know about her crush, they certainly did now—but her anxieties were quelled as soon as Perfuma rang the doorbell. Scorpia made a show of taking Perfuma's coat and personally

pouring her a glass of wine. Perfuma seated herself next to Scorpia at the dining room table, where the group was conversing before they headed outside.

"I'm so sorry that I'm late," Perfuma apologized, flustered. "I had to finish grading some art history papers."

"No problem at all," Scorpia jumped to reply. "We're glad you're here."

"I'm thankful that I don't have to assign papers for my choir students," Bow added before taking a sip of Cabernet.

"For most of my classes, there are no essays, but art history… Well, it's been a lot this year," Perfuma sighed. "But I won't talk about that anymore now. I'm here to relax. Thanks for inviting me, by the way," Perfuma addressed Scorpia.

"My pleasure," Scorpia beamed, her dark eyes sparkling. "But thank Catra for hosting, and Adora for helping to put this together."

Catra then came in from the back porch, stomping her boots to rid them of snow. "I just checked on the fire, and it's blazing. We're good to go."

Each guest put their coat back on and trekked outside to the bonfire. Adora sat next to Catra and enveloped herself in her parka. The fire emitted a nice warmth, but she was still waiting for the heat to reach where she was sitting. Being near Catra made Adora feel warm, though. She looked so beautiful right now, her face illuminated by the orange light of the fire. She was unreal.

"So… I may have brought this," Bow announced, propping a maroon acoustic guitar on his lap. "It's not a campfire without a sing-along, and besides, now Catra can't use the fact that we don't have a guitar as an excuse to not sing."

Catra groaned, "Bow, how many times do I have to tell you I don't sing anymore?"

“How come I always hear you singing when you’re in the bathroom, then?” Entrapta harmlessly wondered aloud, causing an embarrassed Catra to sink further into her lawn chair.

“Well, that explains why I sometimes hear random singing around the house,” Adora laughed. “I thought it was the radio.” Catra buried herself in the hood of her coat.

“Sing, or don’t, but either way… I’m going to play a classic campfire song,” Bow rubbed his hands together in anticipation. He then launched into “Country Roads”, joined by an enthusiastic but slightly off-key Glimmer. The rest of the group slowly started to sing, save for Catra. Adora started to sing even louder while looking directly at her, and finally, Catra broke down and joined in on the harmony part. Adora had never heard her sing before, but her voice was angelic with a charming rasp to it. She could tell that Catra was holding back her full voice right now, and that she could probably belt if she wanted to.

“That wasn’t so bad, was it?” Bow teased Catra, setting down his guitar.

“That was the *only* singing I’m doing tonight,” Catra laid down the law. “It’s time to make s’mores, anyway.” She opened the package of marshmallows so guests could put them on skewers to roast.

Adora stuck her marshmallow directly in the flames, and it caught on fire within seconds. Hastily, she puffed her cheeks and blew out the fire, leaving a fully charred marshmallow in its wake. Catra, who had already roasted a perfectly golden-brown marshmallow, raised an eyebrow at Adora’s marshmallow-roasting technique.

“What?” Adora questioned her, placing the marshmallow onto a graham cracker with chocolate. “Some of us don’t like to wait.”

“I’m with Catra on this one,” Glimmer said, in the process of roasting her own marshmallow. “They taste horrible when they’re burned like that.”

“I beg to differ,” Bow contested, holding up a plate with at least four blackened marshmallows. “They’re delicious. Plus, it’s easy and quick.”

“You’re arguing with a baker here. You’re not gonna win this one, babe.”

“Ooh! New invention idea: the Marshmallowinator 4000,” Entrapta interjected to no one in particular. “A device that would create the perfect roasted marshmallow. I can’t believe nobody’s thought of this yet.”

After the group softly chuckled at their marshmallow discourse, there was a lull in the conversation. Finally, Catra realized why it was so quiet. “Wait. Where are Scorpia and Perfuma?”

Everyone looked around, noticing that the two of them had left their lawn chairs. “I think they slipped away a few minutes ago,” Glimmer replied.

“Huh. Hope everything’s all right,” Bow shrugged. The group went back to fixing their s’mores and enjoying the warmth of the fire.

Before too long, Adora finally heard Scorpia and Perfuma’s footsteps in the snow, and saw them returning to the bonfire hand-in-hand. She motioned to Catra, who grinned at the sight.

“Looks like everything’s all right,” Catra cupped her hand and whispered into Adora’s ear. Adora smiled in agreement, turning back to look at the newfound couple. The two of them radiated joy to the utmost degree. Adora would be lying if she said her heart didn’t ache a bit, watching them together; she wanted that so badly for herself. Well, with one person in particular.

Scorpia gave a thumbs up to Catra, who affectionately shook her head. As she sat down by the fire again, Catra leaned over to her, “Scorpia, you’ve got a little lipstick right… here.” Catra pointed at her own cheek for reference, and Scorpia’s hand flew to where the pink lipstick was on her face.

“So, what were you guys up to?” Entrapta asked innocently.

“Oh, you know. Talking,” Perfuma giggled, obviously lying. “Lost track of time. Hope we didn’t miss too much. Scorp, do you want me to make you a s’more?”

“That’d be great, ‘Fuma,” Scorpia looked at her adoringly.

“You’re already doing nicknames? I told you, you didn’t need the mistletoe,” Catra whispered to Scorpia, but Adora heard it as well.

“I guess you were right,” Scorpia replied softly. “She said she’s liked me all this time. We’re going out to dinner tomorrow night. Thanks again for helping me with this, pal.”

“Don’t mention it.” Catra then met Adora’s gaze and beamed at her. “Adora helped, too.”

The seven friends talked long into the night, and Adora didn’t think she had had that much fun in a long time. Most of her friends back in New York were also Huntara’s, and thus she had lost a lot of them when they broke up. She now spent the most time with her family, seldom getting together with friends her own age. Occasionally, she’d get drinks with Double Trouble after work, but their friendship tended towards competitiveness these days. They weren’t the biggest fan of Hordak, but they sure did care about impressing him.

Adora actually liked being in Bright Moon, as surprising as that would have been merely at the beginning of the week. She knew that she’d have to leave it soon—which was fine, because her life was still in New York—but she’d hold these memories close to her for a long time. And she knew she’d never forget Catra, for better or for worse.

After their guests had left for the night, Catra offered to walk Adora to her lodgement. “I’m glad Scorpia worked up the courage to ask Perfuma out,” she mentioned.

“Yeah, me too. They’re really sweet together.”

“They are.” Catra walked silently with her hands in the pockets of her jacket. When they reached the guest house, Catra opened the door for Adora and then leaned in the doorway. “It’s gonna be a cold night. Text me if you need any blankets.”

Adora’s heart skipped at the kindness of the offer. “Oh, thank you. I’ll probably be all right, though. I like to be cold when I sleep.” It was true, but she’d also feel terrible waking Catra up just to ask her to bring blankets from the main house.

“Well, let me know if you change your mind. Good night, Adora.” Catra gave her a nod and quietly shut the door behind her.

“Good night, Catra,” Adora whispered to herself, kicking off her shoes and lying down on the bed, which was topped with a red and green Christmas quilt. She sighed heartily, resting her head on a pillow, tired from the long day but also strangely energized. What energized her, she wasn’t entirely certain at first. Until she realized it correlated with the butterflies in her chest and the warmth that coursed through her.

Adore froze when the realization hit her. *I think I’m falling in love with Catra.*

Chapter End Notes

i bet you're mad at me for not letting them kiss...

next update: probably dec 13 but i'm dealing with finals so don't be mad at me if it's a bit later than that :)

As the Yule Log Burns

Chapter Summary

> Adora is snapped back into reality, realizing she's running out of time to close the deal. What's it going to be—her big promotion, or her burgeoning relationship with Catra?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Knock, knock,” Adora heard Catra say from outside the guest house’s door, accompanied by two gentle raps. Adora leapt up from her bed to answer.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora bit her lip, trying in vain to prevent her wide smile. She had lain awake the night before, the realization that she was seriously falling for Catra preventing her from sleep. She was trying to be subtle about her feelings—once again, she was here on business—but it was becoming harder than she expected. “What’s up? Not here to dispute the results of our snowball fight yesterday, I hope?”

“Nothing to dispute. You may have won the battle, but I’ll win the war.” Catra’s raspy voice almost made the words sound sultry. “But right now, I’m simply checking in. Being a good hostess, you know?” Catra stood outside the door, and Adora motioned for her to come in. They both sat in the two chairs before the fireplace, which Adora had lit an hour prior.

Catra continued, “I had a really good time last night. I appreciate that you humored Scorpia.”

“I had a great time too,” Adora beamed. “Scorpia and Perfuma seemed so happy, I’m glad we could help them out.”

“Yeah, me too.” Catra poked at the fire, adjusting one of the logs. The fire crackled in response. “Scorpia’s a good friend. Even if

she's overbearing at times. And she and Perfuma are a match made in heaven… They're both two of the kindest people I know. And two of the bubbliest."

"I haven't known either of them for long, but I can tell that's true," Adora agreed.

"Well, anyway… you've been staying here for six days. Has living in a Christmas house driven you crazy yet, you Grinch?" As she spoke, Catra played with a piece of metallic red-and-green tinsel that hung over the fireplace.

Adora rolled her eyes fondly. "I'm still not a fan of Christmas, but I'm holding up. My moms are obsessed with Christmas, so this is nothing new for me. But, I guess I don't *hate* Christmas anymore. I also don't particularly like it, but maybe I'll get there someday."

"Are you ever going to tell me *why* you have it out for such a cheerful holiday? I mean, even hating Halloween makes more sense, because of the fear factor. Did your grandma get run over by a reindeer or something?" Catra teased, laughing to herself. Adora's face fell, and Catra noticed right away. "Hey, you don't have to tell me if it's too personal. I'll feel like an asshole if your grandma actually was run over by a reindeer."

Adora shook her head, smiling weakly, as Catra's joke was not lost on her. "No, no, my grandma is fine. I probably should explain why I've got such a vendetta against Christmas, though. You've opened up to me, and I want to do the same."

"Only if you want to," Catra leaned closer to Adora. "No pressure here."

Adora took a deep breath, feeling her hands shake. She clasped them to stop their quivering. It took her a moment to find the words, since she hadn't explained the situation to anyone in a relatively long time. "My ex—Huntara—you know, the one that was texting me a few days ago? I was going to propose to her on Christmas Eve. We had been dating for three and a half years.

She… she, um, found the ring, and she broke it off before I could even ask. She didn't want to commit to me like that. That was Christmas Eve, so on Christmas day… I was inconsolable. I probably ruined my moms' day, too, with all my crying. And now every time I think of Christmas, or Christmastime, I associate it with Huntara breaking my heart. God, I hate Huntara for ruining my favorite holiday like that. I don't even want her back, I just hate what she did to me." Adora's throat felt tight as she tried to fight tears. But they spilled onto her cheek, regardless, and she put her face in her hands to hide it. She really didn't want to break down in front of Catra.

Catra tenderly touched Adora's shoulder to comfort her. "Hey, hey, it's okay. I'm so sorry that happened to you." Adora's eyes, made glassy by the tears, looked into Catra's heterochromic ones. Catra paused for a moment. "She doesn't deserve you, Adora. Sounds like when she reached out to you a few days ago, she realized what she lost. Because in the last few days I've learned that you're… actually pretty cool." Adora could tell from Catra's tone that she seldom dished out praise like that.

"Well, you are too," Adora replied earnestly. "I know we had our differences at first, but I've really never met anyone like you, Catra."

"That means a lot." Catra's face turned red. "I don't blame you for not liking Christmas, now that I know the reason why." She sighed, looking away. "Logically, I should hate Christmas too. For a lot of reasons."

"What do you mean?"

"I've had some pretty awful Christmases. My stepmother would put me to work in the cold, on Christmas day, when I was just a kid. And I've already told you about some of the other awful things she said and did to me. And her passing only made it worse. I have some terrible memories tied to this farm, and I'm only just starting to heal. But, despite it all, I've stayed."

"That sounds terrible, Catra. I'm sorry, too." Treading lightly, Adora pushed a bit further, mainly out of curiosity. "Why'd you stay? After everything?"

"I still have a lot of good memories here, too. Like I said, I still remember a lot of the times I had with my dad, before he passed. He was one of the best people I'll ever know. And he *loved* Christmas. We'd listen to 'Feliz Navidad' and that one Paul McCartney Christmas song, and we'd dance around the living room, and then he'd make me his homemade hot chocolate recipe." Catra rubbed her forearm, smiling wistfully at the memories. "I've made good memories with my friends here, too. And of course, some with you, this week."

Adora was taken aback by that last part. The thought that her time here had made an impact on Catra warmed her heart. "Well, I should tell you that I've made some awesome memories here too."

Catra abruptly inhaled, "Okay, I'm going to hug you now, and we're going to pretend I didn't, since I'm not usually a hugger and my friends wouldn't let me hear the end of it. Deal?"

"Oh. Uh, deal." Adora leaned in, putting her arms around Catra. She held on tightly for a minute, feeling like she couldn't get close enough. It's not like she was trying to notice, per se, but Catra smelled so good, a mix of pine and cologne. It was intoxicating. Adora was the first to let go, worried she wouldn't be able to if she waited for too long.

But when she let go, she was hit by a crushing wave of guilt. Even if she convinced Catra to sell Driluth Farms, she'd feel horrible. This place was Catra's entire childhood, maybe one of the last ties she had to her late father. If Adora were in Catra's position, what would she do? She doubted she'd want to sell, either. But then again, Catra had already admitted that she didn't have many options at the moment, what with the farm's financial situation. And if Adora couldn't secure this deal? She could kiss her big promotion goodbye.

"All good?" Catra snapped Adora back into the present. She must have been staring off into space.

"Oh, yeah. I… Thank you for listening to my whole Huntara story. And for caring to ask about it. It's nice to talk about it with someone who's not so connected to the situation, since most of my friends at the time were also Huntara's. Unsurprisingly, I don't talk to many of them anymore."

"Seriously, Adora… Any time. I'm still not sure how this business deal is going to end, but I'm here for you if you need anything. I hope we can stay in touch after all of this."

Catra's words brought tears to Adora's eyes once again. Not only because they were so touching, but because she knew that they couldn't be true. No matter what, Horde Realty gaining the property would only hurt Catra. And when that happened, Catra probably wouldn't want to speak to Adora, even if she sold by her own volition. She couldn't even blame Catra for that.

Adora couldn't have her cake and eat it too.

Adora needed a change of scenery, so she started her car to drive into town. Being in that guest house was a constant reminder of the decision she'd have to make. It was either her promotion or Catra's happiness that she'd have to choose. And she'd have to make the choice soon. She had had her fun skating on ponds and riding horses and roasting marshmallows, but she needed to face the music. This was getting real.

She didn't quite have the mental energy to go into any of the shops, even though she really could have gone for some of the pastries from Glimmer's bakery. So instead, she sat in the parking lot of the fairgrounds. A thick layer of fog hung in the air today, obscuring her view while she drove, so she had previously put her

windshield wipers to work. Now that she was parked, the noise vexed her, so she turned them off. Before long, her windshield became obscured by the haze again.

Adora sighed, retrieving her phone from her coat pocket. If there was anyone who could give her advice, or guide her in the right direction, it was probably someone in her family. She pressed the call button on Mara's contact and hoped that both of her moms would be together to talk to her. Unfortunately, Mara didn't answer at all. Adora then called Hope, who picked up on the second ring.

"Hey, sweetie. What's going on?" Hope answered, and Adora could hear Grandma Razz's chatter in the background.

"Oh, hi, Mom. I'm glad you picked up. Is Mara around too? I guess I could just use some advice from both of you."

"Mara has some last-minute wedding planner duties to attend to right now," Hope explained. "There's some sort of calamity with the venue, and the wedding is in a few hours."

"Sounds rough," Adora cringed. "If anyone can handle it, it's her."

"I'm with you there. I'm free for a bit, though, since I haven't opened the shop quite yet. How are things going, Adora?"

" *Ummm* …" Adora lingered on the "m", wondering what part she should start with. "So, I haven't gotten Catra to sell the property yet. And I'm not even sure if that's the right thing to do." Significantly quieter, she added, "Also, I have feelings for her."

"Did I hear that last part correctly?" Hope laughed, clearly having heard it correctly.

"Yes. Yes, you did." Adora facepalmed, not even totally sure why she was admitting this.

"Aww, young love. Just be professional about it, though. Things like that tend to get messy."

"First of all, we're not *that* young. I'm thirty-two, and I think she's about the same. Second of all, I *am* trying to be professional. These feelings have been eating me alive, but it's not like I'd actually make a move. Also, wait. Weren't you guys asking me if she was 'cute' a few days ago?" Adora knew she sounded flustered to the utmost degree, but she couldn't help it. This was a lot to handle.

"Let the record show that your *other* mother asked if Catra was 'cute.' I wash my hands of that. But, Adora, honey… I think you just need to take a minute and relax. Getting worked up isn't going to do you any good."

"But… Catra… the promotion…" Adora could hardly string together a coherent sentence. She was hopeless. She put her head down in defeat, resting it on the steering wheel.

"I know you want this promotion, but it sounds like you really care about Catra, too. All I can tell you is to follow your heart, no matter how cliché that sounds. And anyway, there's a reason why that's a popular saying."

"I don't know *what* my heart—" Adora cut herself off upon realizing she sounded whiney.

"Then take some more time. You have until Christmas Eve, don't you?"

"Christmas Eve Eve, actually." Adora slumped down in the driver's seat of her car. It seemed like she simultaneously had too much time and not enough time to close this deal. *Ugh.*

"Maybe the solution to your troubles isn't so obvious. Think outside the box, Adora. I know you can." Hope sounded maternal and reassuring as always.

"Thank you, Mom. I love you."

"Love you too, honey. I've got to open the shop now, but be in touch, okay?"

"Of course I will. Tell Mara I said hi," Adora signed off, feeling a bit calmer than she did at the start of the call. She didn't feel any closer to a resolution, though.

Adora put her seatbelt back on, deciding to go back to the farm. Maybe she could honestly talk things through with Catra.

Just as Adora was returning her phone to her pocket, it buzzed in her hand. She groaned when she saw that she had a text from Hordak. *Any updates?* It read. She didn't want to answer yet, not until she had figured things out.

If the fact that I'm a lesbian disaster counts as an adequate update, then yes, Adora thought.

Adora came back to the farm to find Catra securing a tree on top of the car of two happy customers. They thanked Catra and drove off, and Catra chuckled to Adora.

"I don't know why they waited so long to get their Christmas tree, since Christmas is next week. But hey, business is business. I'll take it." Catra wiped the sweat from her brow. Annoyingly, she even made sweating look good. Catra took off her flannel and tied it around her waist, the black tank top underneath showing off her biceps.

"Yeah, that's… strange." Adora tried to figure out a way to broach the topic on her mind. "How has business been, by the way? You know, recently?"

Catra shrugged indifferently, but Adora could see the sadness in her eyes. "This year and last year have been about the same, financially. People are showing up for their trees, it's just—this is a small town. There are only so many trees to be bought. Plus, this is a seasonal industry, so…"

“Any more thoughts on selling the farm, then?” Adora asked. “I understand why you’re apprehensive about selling, but it might be the right thing. If it would make a difference, we could raise our bid.”

Catra scowled, crossing her arms. “Wow. I thought with everything we talked about earlier today, you’d get that it’s not about money to me. It’s about family. But your vapid corporate job takes precedence, I guess.” She started back to the house, and Adora could have sworn she was stomping her boots.

Adora’s jaw dropped to the floor. “Catra, *wait* . I didn’t mean to—”

Catra put her hands up, interrupting her. “No, don’t tell me what you meant. You think that the right amount of money is going to sweeten me up. You think that you can buy my compliance. Maybe I can bear selling this farm, but I can’t bear the idea of you thinking of me like that.”

Adora let her walk away, knowing that whatever response she could muster wouldn’t suffice. Her job had been everything to her, but right about now, she despised it.

Chapter End Notes

hey, it's a hallmark movie au, but it still can't be unicorns and rainbows all the time ;)

also... this has been a very stressful week, but i love reading your comments. so, thank you for all the support

next update: dec 17

Scorpia Plays Cupid

Chapter Summary

> Adora gets roped into a movie night with Catra's friends even though the two still aren't speaking. What could go wrong?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Your vapid corporate job takes precedence. The words echoed in Adora's mind on a loop. No matter how many times she tried to distract herself, they came back, like a broken record. How could Catra think of her like that, after everything? Did the last few days have no bearing on Catra's opinion of Adora? Adora hadn't expected to open up to Catra about Huntara, but it was so easy. Everything felt easy with Catra, at least until yesterday. She had felt like they were finally *getting* each other. But clearly, Catra still saw her as nothing more than some evil businesswoman. That hurt Adora more than anything, because she really did care about her.

That night, Adora had knocked on the main house's back door a few times, but Catra wouldn't answer. She also texted her, just in case maybe she hadn't heard the knocks, to no avail. This was highly irritating to Adora—what if she needed a snack, or something?—but she resigned herself to staying in the guest house until Catra cooled off. They would have to talk tomorrow.

For most of that morning and afternoon, Adora attempted to be productive, taking care of some of her other responsibilities. While her main priority was this business with the farm, she still had a glut of work emails to which she needed to respond. Bright Moon Public Library seemed to be a tranquil spot to focus, so she drove there. Apparently everything in this town had to be scenic, including the view from the library's colossal windows; snow-covered mountain peaks were visible in the distance, along with

some picturesque pines behind the building. Seeing the trees made her think of Catra's farm, and her heart panged. *But Catra doesn't have a monopoly on trees, anyway, so I shouldn't be upset,* she reminded herself.

Adora also knew that she had to answer Hordak at some point, since he didn't like to be kept waiting. However, she didn't have the faintest clue of what to say to him. She could tell the truth, that she didn't feel much closer to convincing Catra to sell than when she first got here, or she could lie. She wasn't a skilled liar, though. All she could hope was that he'd get preoccupied with something else and forget about Adora before she could figure something out.

But with the amount of time he'd already spent pestering Adora about this deal, that was unlikely.

When Adora returned from the library, it was mostly dark outside. It was early evening; she must have lost track of time. She noticed two other cars parked beside hers and Catra's truck, and wondered who was visiting Catra. Nearing the main house, she saw Catra, Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta standing on the front porch. Adora hoped that none of the others would notice her, because she wasn't on great terms with Catra at the moment. She didn't want to have whatever conversation would surely ensue if they saw her. Unfortunately, these hopes weren't fulfilled, because Scorpia caught sight of Adora and immediately flagged her down. Not wanting to be rude, Adora sighed and walked over to the group.

"Adora, you're back just in time for our monthly movie night!" Scorpia exclaimed.

"Your monthly movie night?" Adora repeated. *What did I just get myself into?*

"Every month, the three of us—and now Perfuma, too—get together and have a movie marathon. We've been doing it for years, so it's like a best friends' tradition," Entrapta bubbled,

playing with one of her long ponytails. “Why don’t you join us? I’m sure it’ll be even more fun with five of us.”

“Oh, I’m sure Adora’s way too busy to join us,” Catra protested, shooting a lethal glance at her friends. “Wouldn’t want to bother her.”

“She won’t be in town for much longer, so this is her only chance to do a movie night with all of us. I’m sure she can stay for at least one movie,” Scorpia countered, glaring back at Catra. Maybe Catra had told her friends about her and Adora’s recent discordance, and now Scorpia was trying to intervene. Adora wouldn’t be surprised if that were the case.

“Um, I…” Adora tried to muster an excuse to avoid what would undoubtedly be a very awkward movie night with Catra, considering how tense things were. Then she realized that she had avoided Catra for long enough, and at some point, they were going to have to speak again. “You know what? I’d actually love to. I got plenty of work done today at the library.”

“See? She *can* join us,” Scorpia retorted to Catra.

“Yay, this is going to be so much fun!” Perfuma squealed. “Let’s go inside and pick our movies for tonight. I brought a few DVDs, just in case.”

“Yeah, so much fun,” Catra deadpanned, staring Adora straight in the face. Adora narrowed her eyes in defiance.

The first movie on their list was one of those claymation Christmas movies, but Adora was barely paying attention to what was on the screen. No, what occupied her thoughts was the seating arrangement that Scorpia had finagled. In Catra’s TV room, there were two maroon sofas with a matching chair in

between. Scorpia saw to it that she and Perfuma took one sofa while Entrapta took the small chair (seriously, she moved everyone around like chess pieces), leaving Catra and Adora to take the other sofa. Adora knew exactly what Scorpia was doing: playing matchmaker. She already knew of Scorpia's suspicions after she had caught Catra and Adora in an… ahem, *uncomfortable* position during the snowball fight a couple days ago. Well, Scorpia wasn't wrong about how Adora felt, at least. Still, nobody needed to know that; Adora did all she could to distance herself from Catra, practically hanging off the edge of the sofa. Maybe she and Catra were more on the same page than she thought, because the farmer did the same. There were a few much-appreciated feet between them as they watched the movie. Still, Adora could sense Catra's hostility, even from a small distance. She had *not* wanted Adora to be a part of this movie night, which was obviously why she hadn't asked her to join in the first place.

To make matters worse, Scorpia decided about halfway through the movie that she'd go and get blankets for everyone. Conveniently, she only gave Catra and Adora one blanket to share, forcing them to scooch slightly closer together. Her leg accidentally touched Catra's for a second, but Adora immediately retracted it. "It's getting kind of cold in here, and I don't want to go through the trouble of setting up the fireplace," Scorpia explained, her true motives painfully transparent.

Adora and Catra sat like that for about ten minutes, not daring to look at each other. She could feel Catra stewing in perturbation next to her, as clearly she wasn't happy about Scorpia's latest stunt. Finally, Catra got up and beckoned for Scorpia to talk to her in the kitchen.

"Do you want us to pause the movie…?" Perfuma asked tentatively, adjusting her flower crown.

"No, this will only be a minute," Catra said through gritted teeth. "It would be *heartless* of me to make you sacrifice your time like

that. Don't wait for us." She pulled Scorpia into the kitchen without hesitation.

Okay, the "heartless" part was definitely directed at me, though it didn't make that much sense, Adora realized. She, Perfuma, and Entrapta looked at each other with wide eyes, unwittingly overhearing Catra and Scorpia's strained murmurs from the adjacent room. The only tidbits Adora could pick out were "stop meddling" and "farm". Those fragments could have meant anything, but Adora assumed that, on a basic level, Catra wanted to put a stop to Scorpia's "meddling". Specifically, in her relationship with Adora. Adora placed her palm over her forehead in embarrassment. She knew that she was probably blushing up a storm right now, too.

Scorpia sheepishly walked back into the TV room. "Catra's, uh, going to take a breather upstairs."

"Why?" Entrapta asked, shoving a handful of popcorn in her mouth.

"No reason. No reason at all. She'll be back before we start our second movie." Scorpia's eyes nervously darted around the room.

Hands down, the weirdest movie night of my life, Adora thought. *My salary pays for an apartment in Manhattan, but I really don't think it pays enough for* this *.*

"I'm going to the bathroom really quick," Adora announced, thinking of an excuse on the fly to get out of the TV room. "Don't pause the movie." She scurried away without waiting for a response. Perhaps she could find Catra upstairs and finally clear the air.

Adora practically stumbled into Catra when she reached the upstairs hallway. Catra was standing there, leaning against the wall as if she had been awaiting Adora's arrival.

"I was looking for the bathroom," Adora lied. She took a moment to examine the upstairs hallway, as she had never seen it before,

and quickly noticed that it was just as decorated for Christmas as the rest of the house. There were Christmas lights lining the ceiling. That was dedication.

"No, you weren't." Catra didn't budge.

"You're right. I wasn't. I was looking for you," Adora sighed. "I don't want it to be like this anymore. Please, will you just talk to me?"

Catra crossed her arms, silently contemplating. "Okay, I'm still a little bit mad, but I admit that I've been too harsh. And maybe immature, at times, especially when I refused to hear you out. So, yes."

Adora pressed her hands together. "Thank you, Catra." She took a deep breath before continuing. "I'm really sorry for giving the impression that this is only about money to me. It's not, at all. I know it's my job to negotiate with you, but that doesn't mean I don't care about what the implications of selling the farm are for you. I promise you, I want to take your concerns into account."

"And I'm sorry for insulting you and your job. That really wasn't cool of me. I might have been angry at the time, but I know that you're not vapid or heartless. In fact, you have one of the best hearts I've encountered in a long time."

"I *knew* you were calling me heartless," Adora gasped playfully, putting a hand over her mouth. "What did you even mean, though? About sacrificing time, or something?"

"In hindsight, the message wasn't the clearest," Catra bit her lip, suppressing a laugh. "I guess I just worried that maybe all of the time we've spent together this week didn't mean anything to you. It's stupid, I know."

"Yeah, it *is* stupid," Adora replied, "because of course it's meant a lot to me. I won't stop reminding you that you let me, effectively a stranger at the time, stay in your guest house. You've been so

welcoming and kind, and you were a really good listener when I was telling you about my personal stuff with Huntara yesterday."

Catra's cheeks turned red. "Of course. I'd do that for any friend. And you are my friend, Adora, even if we're friends in some of the most unlikely circumstances." She shook her head fondly, "I wasn't even that mad at you, honestly. Trying to be mad at you is like… trying to be mad at a golden retriever. It's useless."

"What does that mean?" Adora raised an eyebrow.

"You're just too likable," Catra explained reluctantly. Adora couldn't help but grin. "Don't make me elaborate. Anyway, the movie… we should probably get back to it. Not to be weird, but they probably think we're making out up here."

" *Uhhh* …" Adora pondered that for a second and realized that it was unequivocally true, but she still played dumb. "W-why would they think that?"

Catra shrugged. "Scorpia thought we were about to kiss after our snowball fight. Hilarious, right?"

Adora's chest pained her. Catra *definitely* didn't think there was anything between them—in fact, that was probably why she kept emphasizing that Adora was her "friend". But they could never be together, anyway. Adora had to stop getting her hopes up about that when it was quite literally impossible. Hoping her voice wouldn't betray her melancholy, she replied, "Yeah, that's… crazy. We should probably go back, then." The two of them started downstairs, but Adora's phone started ringing. *Hordak, dammit.* "Hold on, this is my boss. I have to take this, sorry," Adora frowned, stepping back upstairs to take the call. Apparently, he saw fit to call at any hour of the day.

"H-Hey, Hordak. Sorry I didn't answer your text, I've just been really busy with negotiating this deal and I'm making a ton of progress, I really think I'm close—" she started blabbering, but he cut her off.

"Slow down, Adora," Hordak interrupted calmly. "If that's true, that's wonderful to hear. I'm not so sure that it *is* true, however."

"What do you mean?" Adora knew her quavering voice had given her away. *I'm a terrible liar, and he knows it.*

"The Adora I know would have been back in New York *yesterday.* You're more than halfway through your twelve days, Adora. What's going on?"

"These things take time, you know," Adora defended herself. "Plus, Catra—er, Ms. Driluth—she's still not sure that she wants to sell the farm. I've been doing my best to convince her, though, and I'll do whatever it takes to make sure that this works out for us."

"It's your *job* to convince her, Adora. You had better do it, and soon. I hope you are serious about doing whatever it takes. If buying the farm costs more than we had previously anticipated, I can live with that. This mall is going to be worth it. Tell Ms. Driluth she can name her price."

I tried that yesterday, and look how that panned out, Adora winced. "Yes, of course. Don't worry, I'll get this done." Adora was losing faith in "getting this done" by the minute. Everything about convincing someone to sell the farm they grew up on felt plain wrong. But she had to get Hordak off her back, at least until she knew what she wanted.

"We're all rooting for you, Adora. Remember that promotion?"

"I couldn't forget it." *That's why I'm here, Hordak. Duh.*

"Well, I have to go now, but please keep me updated. Wrap up this deal, Adora." Hordak hung up without another word.

Adora slid down against the wall, wrapping her arms around her knees. She felt conflicted about every aspect of her life: personal, professional, or otherwise. She took a minute to herself to process

the phone call with Hordak, but then went back downstairs. She didn't want to keep the group waiting for too long.

"All right, I'm back," Adora took her spot next to Catra on the sofa, this time not making any effort to distance herself. Catra's eyes twinkled as she offered some of the quilted blanket to Adora, who nodded in appreciation. "What are we watching now?" she asked.

"I was thinking we could watch *The Nightmare Before Christmas* ," Entrapta suggested, holding the DVD case in her hand. "It's a classic."

"No way, that's *way* more of a Halloween movie," Scorpia rebuffed.

"I love a good Halloween movie, I just don't like to mix Halloween and Christmas," Catra agreed.

"Hold on, you don't like *The Nightmare Before Christmas?"* Adora passionately rebuked Catra's statement. "It's totally a Christmas movie. It's both Halloween and Christmas, that's the point."

"I'm surprised that you want to watch a Christmas movie at all," Catra said to Adora. "Are you finally a Christmas enjoyer again?" Adora stuck out her tongue at Catra.

"I could go either way," Perfuma shrugged. "I just want to watch a movie with you guys." She kissed Scorpia on the cheek, and Scorpia blushed.

"I'll watch it, but only because the music in the film is so good," Catra conceded. She turned to Adora, "And I only know that because this isn't the first time Entrapta's tried to get us to watch it."

"I believe the majority have agreed with me," Entrapta pumped her fist in the air triumphantly. " *Nightmare Before Christmas* it is!" She dashed to the DVD player and popped in the disk.

As the movie began, Catra's phone buzzed and she looked at its screen. "Adora, Glimmer and Bow just texted us and asked if they could come over tomorrow. They're bringing the cookies that the bakery's presenting at the Christmas Carnival for the Christmas cookie contest. Glimmer wants us to test them out beforehand."

"Sounds good to me. Wait, Christmas carnival?" Adora inquired.

"They're talking about the annual Bright Moon Christmas Carnival. It's a *big* deal in Bright Moon. Like, everyone goes."

" *Everyone* ," the rest of the group echoed.

"Oh, cool. When is it, then?"

"The twenty-first. It's usually on the winter solstice," Perfuma answered. "It's so much fun. There's food, hot chocolate, carolers, a big Ferris wheel, you name it. Bright Moon's tree lighting was earlier this month, but you'll see the town's Christmas tree at the Carnival. It's one of Catra's trees, by the way."

"Oh, stop," Catra *pffed* . "I'm the only tree farmer in town."

"But it's your tree! Don't be so humble, pal," Scorpia chastised her. She quickly threw in, "The Christmas Carnival is super romantic, by the way. Just thought I'd mention that."

"So I assume you and Perfuma are going together?" Adora asked, expertly diverting the attention away from her and Catra. Scorpia wasn't finished matchmaking yet, evidently.

"We haven't talked about it, actually." Scorpia looked at Perfuma. "We are, though… Right, babe?"

"Of course we are, silly," Perfuma giggled. "You're my girlfriend."

"Just thought I'd make sure," Scorpia wiped the sweat from her brow.

“Okay, we all love each other, *yada yada* . You’re missing the movie with all of this chitter-chatter,” Entrapta scolded lightheartedly. “If we’re not going to watch, I’m going to go back to the shop and work on my tech.”

“No need, Entrapta. We’ll shut up.” Catra sat forward and focused her attention on the TV screen.

Sometime during their third movie of the night, everyone in the group fell asleep. Adora jolted awake at about 2 a.m., glimpsing the time on her watch. The others were soundly slumbering. The movie must have ended, because the DVD screensaver was repeatedly bouncing around the screen, annoyingly never reaching the corner.

Adora almost stood up to grab a glass of water, but she realized that there was a weight on her. Catra’s head leaned on Adora’s shoulder peacefully. *Shit.* Adora didn’t want to disturb her, but she figured it probably wasn’t a good idea for this to continue. It was really adorable, though. Still, she carefully moved her shoulder, taking great pains not to move Catra too much. Before she stood up, she adjusted the blanket so that it better covered Catra.

Adora went to the kitchen and filled her class, then slipped her snow boots back on so that she could return to the guest house and sleep. “Good night, Catra,” she whispered before she left.

Chapter End Notes

hope you enjoyed chapter 7!

let me know... would yall mind if the last chapter of this story is published a couple days after christmas? some unexpected life events messed up my previous release schedule lmao

Sugar & Spice

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra have reconciled, but their feelings come to a head when they spend a day with Glimmer and Bow.

Chapter Notes

brace yourselves. i won't tell you what that means

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer stopped by the farm to enlist Adora and Catra in testing her baked goods. She had placed an assortment of Sugar, Spice, and Sparkles' finest festive bakes on Catra's kitchen counter. Glimmer told them, "I've got to make an important decision, and I need your help. Which do I present at the Christmas Carnival?" She presented a plate with two different types of spritz cookies. One was an incredibly detailed Christmas tree, and the other was a jolly-looking snowman. Adora and Catra both took one of each and tried them.

"I might be biased, but I've got to go with the Christmas tree," Catra said, still chewing on the cookie.

"And what about you, Adora?" Glimmer motioned at the two half-eaten cookies on Adora's plate.

"I like the hint of cinnamon in the snowman cookie, but I have to agree with Catra," Adora affirmed.

"Christmas tree it is," Glimmer grinned, satisfied with their responses. "I'll have to whip up a huge batch soon. You should have seen how quickly the town ate through these cookies last year."

"Why can't you bring both, then?" Adora asked.

"The bakery is already presenting gingerbread cookies, peppermint cupcakes, hot chocolate bites, and apple glazed donuts at the Carnival. I don't want our selection to be too *busy,* you know? We have to represent ourselves well. This is one of our biggest gigs of the year."

"Yeah, Sparkles, I'm sure Bright Moon will riot if you put out the trees *and* the snowmen," Catra tittered.

"Um, you run a business too, Catra. You should know better than anyone how important the details are," Glimmer retorted. "Even the smallest things can make a huge difference in the profits we rake in."

"Fair point," Catra granted her, but not without rolling her eyes. She muttered, "I should know that better than anyone." Adora noticed that her mouth was slightly curved into a frown, probably because she was thinking about the farm's troubles. She recovered quickly, though. "All right, what are we trying next?"

Glimmer rifled through the several cookie containers she had brought with her. "I need opinions on these peppermint cupcakes. Let me know if the flavor is too strong or too weak." She gave each of them a cupcake with a red liner and peppermint bark garnishing the white frosting.

"Mm, this is delicious," Adora commented, licking her fingers. "Are you sure our input is going to be much help, though? I bet that teenager working at your bakery knows more about the culinary arts than me."

"Same here. I cook a lot, but I'm pretty helpless when it comes to baking," Catra added.

"I needed a break from that place," Glimmer sighed, leaning against the fridge. "Frosta is a good kid, but her personality is a bit strong even for me sometimes. Not to mention she can't go a week without a kitchen disaster. Honestly, I just needed a change of scenery. I feel like I've been holed up in there for *days* coming

up with these creations." Sheepishly, she continued while looking at Catra, "Also, there's another reason I'm here. Bow sort of wants to convince you to reunite Cyra."

Catra groaned dramatically. "Oh, you've got to be kidding. *That* again?"

"Where is Bow, by the way?" Adora looked around. Her question was answered by the sound of a car pulling up outside.

"He was late because he insisted on packing all of his instruments into the bakery's delivery truck. He told me to leave without him," Glimmer explained. "I'll let him in now."

"Sounds like I'm finally going to hear your band in all its glory," Adora teased Catra, stealing a gingerbread cookie from the stash.

"Not if I can help it," Catra quipped. Bow then skidded into the room wearing both a guitar and a keytar, and a tambourine around his wrist. Catra shook her head. "Bow, I already told you __"

"That you sold your guitar? Well, I know that's not true because I accidentally found it in one of your closets when I was looking for a bathroom during the bonfire, but not to worry. I've got plenty of instruments for both of us, including a guitar for you." Bow twinkled as he lifted the guitar off himself. He handed it to Catra, who took it reluctantly. She grimaced when she inadvertently plucked a few strings during the exchange, causing a twangy clash of notes.

"Apparently I'm out of excuses, so… yes, I'll play *later* . Although, maybe I'll have thought of some more excuses by then," Catra scoffed, carefully setting the guitar down.

"Come on, Catra, you're really good. Adora has to hear you perform before she leaves," Glimmer implored Catra.

"A compliment? From Sparkles? That rare event might actually be enough to get me to sing," Catra wisecracked.

"Note to Glimmer: continue complimenting Catra," Bow said to his wife. He then turned to the farmer. "Anyway, I have a reason for asking you to play in the band with me. The Bright Moon Christmas Carnival needs more acts to play the pavilion during the evening. I've already booked the choir, and somehow they got a Michael Bublé impersonator, but we really could use one more act. And I was thinking…" Bow widened his eyes expectantly.

"What? You want me to perform in front of the entire town? Forget it," Catra dismissed him. Everyone else was silent as they stared at Catra. She continued, "Hey, don't judge me. Listen, I love the Carnival, but let me stick to what I know. Trees."

"But you *do* know music, Catra," Glimmer pointed out.

"If you perform at the Carnival, I'll try to stop complaining about Christmas for good," Adora offered, holding out a hand to the farmer.

Catra thought long and hard, but she firmly shook Adora's hand. "All right. Deal. But don't try to convince me to go on a full Cyra reunion tour."

Bow chuckled heartily. "Hey, I'm just glad we got you for the Carnival. We'd better start rehearsing soon if we want to be ready, though. Glimmer and Adora, you're more than welcome to listen."

"I wouldn't miss it for the world," Adora replied.

After Bow and Catra set up in the living room and tuned their instruments (it turned out they hadn't actually needed the flute, violin, or full drum kit Bow insisted upon bringing), they called Glimmer and Adora in. The two of them sat on the couch in front of the musicians.

“This brings me right back to high school,” Glimmer remarked fondly, smiling at her husband.

“Yeah, we were always making music in my garage back then. And Glimmer handled the management side of things, like making our event posters. It was so much fun for us, but I think my parents just tolerated the noise sometimes.” Everyone chuckled at the thought. “Any requests for what we should play first?” Bow asked the group.

“Actually, I have one I’d like to start with,” Catra cut in. She whispered her idea to Bow, who nodded giddily. They both prepared their instruments for the song; Bow held his tambourine in one hand while Catra put on her guitar. She looked over at Bow and counted off the start of the song, hesitantly strumming the opening chords. When she opened her mouth to sing, the heavenly sound of her voice could have made anyone stop and listen.

I've been spending my attention on you, on you

I don't wait long, 'cause I got better things to do

When you gonna take me out?

Make a move and make it now

When you gonna take me out?

It wasn’t a song Adora recognized, so it must have been one of Cyra’s originals. She wondered why Catra had wanted to play this song in particular. Adora bashfully avoided eye contact with her, but she could feel the heavy gaze of Catra’s gold-and-blue eyes on her as she played. It wasn’t a creepy gaze, simply passionate.

I know that you would want it

If I could sink my teeth into you

First, you gotta ask me out

Catra didn't break her steadfast gaze on Adora, whose heart skipped a beat when she realized the implication of what she was singing. Adora felt as though she were in a trance-like state as Catra repeated the verses, accompanied by Bow's harmonies. Sure, it was just a song—and a years-old one, at that, so it couldn't have been written about Adora—but Catra was still looking directly at Adora while singing a *romantic* song that she had specifically asked to play. Was she reading too far into this, or did it really mean something? Adora had already brushed off so many signs… With all of those taken into account, it didn't seem so crazy that Catra could be into Adora.

Catra only shyly glanced away at the end of the song, when she had played the final chord. Adora and Glimmer cheered and clapped for Catra and Bow, the latter giving them a triumphant grin. He turned to Catra, "That wasn't so hard, was it? You were awesome."

Seemingly flustered, Catra took off her guitar and laid it on a chair. "No, it wasn't too bad. I just need some air, though. I'll be right back," she excused herself and slipped on her snow boots before stepping onto the back porch. She gently closed the back door behind her.

"That was really good, Bow," Adora reassured him. "But, um… should I check on her?"

"It's your call," Glimmer said, "but it's probably best if you do it." She and Bow gave each other knowing glances.

"Why's that?" Adora asked cluelessly. Bow vigorously shook his head at Glimmer, thinking Adora couldn't see him.

"Because you've been staying here with her all week. You clearly know her pretty well," Glimmer explained innocently, but Adora had already figured out what she really meant. Could *everyone* sense her romantic tension with Catra?

Adora's face turned bright red. "Oh, right. I'm going to go talk to her now." She would have gone anywhere to avoid the "I-know-how-you-feel-about-Catra" looks that the married couple were giving her. She opened the back door and found Catra standing under the porch, its awning shielding her from the slow fall of snow. Catra had her back to Adora and didn't immediately notice her presence.

"Hey," Adora said softly. Catra whipped around, startled when she saw Adora standing in the porch light.

"Adora, listen, I—" Catra ran her hands through her hair. "I'm sorry for the way I acted in there. I got carried away during the song."

"You don't have to apologize to me, Catra," Adora replied firmly, not sure where Catra was going. Her heart rate started to pick up. "I'm fine."

"No, really, I'm sorry. Because I can't control the way I feel around you anymore," Catra reiterated, inhaling shakily. "And I know it's wrong because you live hours away in your big city and your firm is trying to *buy my farm* for Pete's sake but… I can't lie anymore."

"Catra, I…" Adora, in processing the depth of Catra was saying to her, couldn't find her own response. "Are you—"

"What I'm going to do next… just blame it on the mistletoe, okay?" Catra's eyes trailed to the awning above them, and Adora followed her line of vision. A shrub of green, tied with a ruby-red ribbon and dotted with white berries, hung from the awning. *Mistletoe.* It was the bushel Scorpia had brought on the day of the bonfire, but never ended up using. Catra had hung it after all.

Catra actually wants to kiss me. Like Catra had already said, Adora knew why it was wrong, but she couldn't hold back anymore, either. Maybe they could just have this one moment. Dismissing her inhibitions, Adora leaned into Catra and cupped one hand around her face. Catra smiled and took the lead, her lips ever so slightly touching Adora's until she gave in entirely and kissed her. It was magical. Adora knew that all the time she had waited had been worth it, for just this one moment. An eternity passed before she pulled away, but her forehead was still pressed to Catra's.

"I, um, forgot to take it down," Catra looked up at the plant.

"Sure you did," Adora rolled her eyes.

"Like I said, blame the mistletoe. You can forget that ever happened for the rest of your time here," Catra muttered glumly. "I-If that's what you want."

"I don't have any intention of doing that," Adora countered, her expression serious. It had taken some thought, but she knew what she wanted now. She was sure.

"Wait, what?" Catra sounded genuinely confused. "But we're… You work for—"

"Yeah, yeah, I work for Horde Realty. But you're not going to sell us the farm," Adora grinned. She knew she'd have to explain further. "At least, I don't think you will."

"Adora, I need some context here," Catra rubbed her temples. She was still perplexed. "How do you know I'm not going to sell you the farm? That's why you came to Bright Moon."

"True, but as of right now, I'm relinquishing the task I was sent here to do. I'm not going to try to convince you to sell Driluth Farms anymore," Adora declared as she put a foot down, and Catra's face immediately lit up. "The more I've been thinking about it, the harder it is to fathom bulldozing a place that means so much to you. So… whatever I do, I'm going to work with you to find a way to save the farm."

“Are you serious?” Catra emitted a laugh of relief, tightly hugging Adora. “I honestly don’t know how we’re going to pull this off, but… Thank you, Adora. You don’t have to do this—you’re probably risking your job—but you…” Adora couldn’t see Catra’s face as they were still wrapped up in their hug, but she was sure that Catra’s eyes had welled up with tears.

Adora hugged her back, enjoying the feeling of being close to Catra above all else. “Hordak doesn’t need to know that I’m doing this. I’ll tell him that the deal just didn’t work out, and he might be disappointed with me, but he won’t fire me. Besides… I really don’t know how I feel about my job anymore. I’m going to have to reconsider what I want for my career.”

Catra let go of Adora, looking her in the face. “For real, this means a lot to me. Also, I don’t blame you. Hordak seemed like kind of a jerk in the one phone conversation I had with him. Like, he probably has an evil lair somewhere.”

Adora snickered at Catra’s description of Hordak. “Yeah, that would be his office. He’s not always an easy boss to work for.”

“You don’t say?”

“Yeah, he sent me to Pennsylvania without getting me a hotel reservation and I had to stay with this stubborn Christmas tree farmer. It’s okay, though, because she’s really hot,” Adora joked.

“Wow, wild story. I hear the representative he sent is even hotter, though,” Catra fired back without missing a beat. She cleared her throat, “We should probably go back inside. I think we’ve kept them waiting long enough.”

Adora nodded, holding the door open for Catra and following her inside. She knew the look on her face would probably give away what just happened, but she couldn’t be bothered to care. Bow and Glimmer sat on the couch in very unnatural positions, like they had been trying to hide the fact that they hadn’t been planted there the whole time.

“*Heeeyyy*, guys,” Bow greeted them conspicuously, warranting a raised eyebrow from both Adora and Catra and a facepalm from Glimmer.

“How much of our conversation did you two hear?” Catra asked critically.

“Not much at all, just a few things here and there,” Glimmer fibbed.

“So basically the whole thing,” Adora filled in the blanks.

“Yeah, basically the whole thing,” Bow admitted as Glimmer slumped against the couch.

Catra and Adora shared a look, and took each other’s hands. “So now you know,” Catra grinned shyly.

Adora couldn’t stop smiling, either.

Chapter End Notes

welp they FINALLY kissed!!

the song was "take me" by aly & aj because it's not a catradora fic without an a&a mention thrown in!

i'm giving you two chapters today, so just keep reading ;)

Snowed In

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra work together to save the farm. When heavy snow confines them both to the main house, neither one of them can hold back their temptations.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Catra spent most of the following morning going through the farm's financial records, from its first year all the way to the present. Adora was still floating after their kiss the night before, but she and Catra seemed to have an unspoken agreement that all of *that* could wait until they knew how they were going to save the farm. Because if they couldn't save it, Catra would still have to sell it.

Papers were scattered across Catra's dining room table, begging to be analyzed. Perhaps there was some information here that could shed a light on *why* Driluth Farms had been going under for the last couple years. The two of them figured they'd need coffee to get through the litany of records, so Catra made an entire pot of it. It didn't take them long to drink it all up, so she brewed another.

"I can't believe I didn't go through these earlier, not that Shadow Weaver ever let me touch the files," Catra shook her head at one of the papers in disbelief. Adora leaned over her shoulder to examine it as well. It was a record from 2011. "She told me the farm was doing fine back then. Actually, the entire time she was alive, she told me that business was booming."

"It wasn't, I'm guessing?"

"Correct. Apparently, I should have been more suspicious, because things have been going downhill for ten years. I'm

thinking she might have been the one to run this place into the ground, not me. And here I believed it was all my fault."

"Wow. These records don't exactly reflect a 'booming business,'" Adora scoffed. "She completely lied to you. I'm sorry, Catra." She squeezed Catra's hand and sat down next to her, a refilled coffee mug in her other hand.

"It's hard for anything she does—did—to shock me. It just pisses me off that she's not even alive and I'm still dealing with the consequences of her actions." Catra pursed her lips, dropping the piece of paper on the table.

Adora tried to reassure Catra. "Think of it this way. You can control what you do with the business *now,* right?"

"Yeah, *if* I can figure something out," Catra fretted. "So far, I've got nothing. Let's just keep looking through these records, and maybe I'll think of something. Maybe we can look at the records from the years my dad owned the farm."

"Sounds like a plan." Adora thumbed through some files from the '90s. "Here, you can take half of these." Catra nodded and started to scan the records.

"Things were a lot easier back then," Catra sighed wistfully. "It took a while to turn a profit after my dad decided to get into tree farming, but apparently… business was going pretty well before he passed." Adora gave her an empathetic look. Catra continued, "I remember when he used to do horse-drawn sleigh rides with the customers. I'd tag along half the time, too."

"That's really sweet," Adora giggled.

"Yeah, it was. Wish things were still that simple." Catra shook her head. Adora unwittingly shivered as the bitter coldness from outside was starting to seep indoors. It had been lightly snowing all day. "Are you cold?" Catra asked her, concerned.

“A little bit,” Adora said nonchalantly, not wanting to make a big deal out of it.

“It’s okay, we can start the fire. I’m going to get some wood, but I’ll be right back. Let me know if you think of anything in the next two minutes.” Catra had the fireplace lit before too long, so she and Adora moved their operations closer to it to stay warm. Adora thanked her for starting the fire, since she really had felt chilly. They sat next to each other on the couch, warmed up by the fire and a holly quilted blanket.

“Back to work, I guess,” Adora said, feeling at a loss for ideas. *Think outside of the box.* Hope’s words from before spiraled in Adora’s mind. That was it! Adora had been approaching this problem all wrong. “Hold on, I think I’ve got something,” Adora rubbed her hands together.

“Wait, really? Give me what you’ve got,” Catra sat up eagerly.

Adora rhetorically asked, “There are a lot of Christmas tree farms in this country, so how are you going to set yourself apart?” Catra cocked her head, listening attentively. Adora gestured, painting a picture of her idea, “Make the farm an *experience* . Bring back the sleigh rides. Open up the skating pond to customers. Utilize the entire property. There’s so much untapped potential here, you can do anything.”

“That’s actually not a bad idea,” Catra pondered, scratching her chin. “I just don’t know if it’s going to be enough.”

“I wasn’t finished yet,” Adora grinned mischievously. “A Christmas tree farm with live music performances. I don’t think a single one of those exists in this country, much less Pennsylvania. Imagine how cool that would be.”

“Oh, I don’t think I—”

“You don’t have to perform. Unless you want to, of course. But you *could* choose the talent. If they’re good enough, customers

might travel miles to see them. And they can get a tree while they're at it." Adora confidently crossed her arms.

Catra silently pondered the suggestion. Adora watched her nervously, hoping she wouldn't reject it outright. Finally, she spoke again. "Oh, what the hell? I'm willing to try anything. And I have to admit that it's a pretty unique business model."

"Hey, I try," Adora jokingly flipped her hair. "One more thing. Don't you think you might want a business manager of sorts? To oversee the things I just mentioned?"

"I mean, yeah, but I don't know where I'd find one," Catra replied.

"You're looking at her," Adora pointed at herself.

"Wait, you want to work… *here?* For me?" Catra gaped at her. "But your real estate job—"

"Isn't for me," Adora finished. "You were right. I've been thinking about it, and Hordak *is* a jerk. And an awful boss. The workplace environment is terrible, too. I'd much rather work where I know the personnel are lovely. Well, it's actually just one person. You." Catra blushed in response, resting her chin on her hand. Adora continued, "Here I could manage projects that I really care about."

"I don't even know how to thank you for this, Adora." Catra warmly embraced her.

"Don't. Just forgive me for trying to convince you to let us bulldoze this farm to build a mall."

"Well, the farm is still here. That's what matters." Catra said the words without a hint of jest. Suddenly, something caught her eye and she walked over to the window. "Sorry to ruin the moment, but the snow is coming down in sheets now. It's actually really bad."

Adora joined Catra at the window and looked through the glass pane. The gentle flakes from earlier in the day had been replaced by rapidly cascading globules. They were the kind that stuck to the ground, too, and had piled up significantly. There were already several feet of snow outside. "How did we not notice this before? Do you think it's even possible to get outside?"

"That much snow would have blocked the back door by now, granted that it's not too frozen to open. I don't know if you'll be able to get back to the guest house." She went over to the TV and turned on the Weather Channel. "There's a blizzard warning for this area. I'm not surprised we didn't hear about it. It's also freezing out, so you definitely shouldn't go outside until morning, at least."

"Where am I going to sleep?" Adora asked.

"There's a spare room in here," Catra informed her, "But there's also my room. If you don't mind sharing a bed with me," she smirked.

Adora stepped closer to Catra, putting her hands around her waist. "I really wouldn't mind," she bit her lip, taking in the fact that she could finally— *finally* —be with Catra. No more worrying about stupid professionalism and/or what Hordak wanted. Just Catra, in her arms.

"But first, I wanna kiss you by the fire," Catra whispered to her, "because I've been holding back all this time and now I don't have to anymore. I want you, Adora." The words made Adora's knees go weak.

"I want you too, Catra," Adora breathed, her face inches from Catra's. Catra kissed her again, setting her ablaze. In the midst of their kiss, they stumbled over to the couch by the fireplace, Catra laying Adora down on the cushions. Her knee pressed into Adora's thighs as the fire burned behind them. Adora couldn't get enough of the feeling.

“My room?” Catra said only two simple words, but Adora knew exactly what they meant. She nodded eagerly. Catra scooped her over her shoulder and brought her upstairs, Adora laughing the whole way.

Adora blissfully lay next to Catra in her bed, one arm wrapped around Catra’s torso. Catra’s sheets faintly smelled like pine, and it was a comforting aroma to Adora. “You know, since the day we met, I’ve been trying to push down my feelings for you, because I thought it was wrong by principle, and I didn’t think you liked me back.” Adora looked over at Catra, wondering how she’d respond.

“Are you kidding?” Catra guffawed, as if the idea was outlandish. “I thought it was so obvious that I had feelings for you. We almost kissed after the snowball fight! Even all my friends could tell I liked you.”

“I thought I was reading too far into things,” Adora mumbled, embarrassed. “And when you said it was ‘ridiculous’ that Scorpia thought we were kissing…”

“I was trying to throw you off the scent because I didn’t want *you* to know I liked you. I knew you cared about professionalism and I didn’t want to make you uncomfortable,” Catra explained. “Plus, my friends were kind of embarrassing me. I’m pretty private about my romantic life, which irks them to no end.”

“So, essentially, we were both hopeless. If it hadn’t been for Scorpia’s mistletoe, *this* might not have happened,” Adora chuckled, gesturing at herself and Catra.

“I guess I’ll have to thank her after all,” Catra agreed. “There’s something else I need to ask you, though.” Her tone was serious, so Adora started to worry.

“Sure, what's up?”

“Will you be my date to the Bright Moon Christmas Carnival? I can’t imagine going to it without you,” Catra confessed. “I promise it’ll be fun.”

Adora’s heart fluttered. “Of course I will. That’ll be our first date, you know. It sounds pretty romantic to me, too.”

“You’re right, it will be our first date. So I probably should warn you, it’s very Christmas-heavy,” Catra teased.

“Yeah, hence the name. I figured ‘Christmas-heavy’ was implied,” Adora rolled her eyes. “Besides… I might be starting to like Christmas again. I don’t think I’ll have any problems with the festival. Plus, I wouldn’t pass up the opportunity to see Cyra perform.”

“*Awww*, I got you to open your heart to Christmas?” Catra cooed, clearly planning to give Adora a hard time about this revelation.

“Hey, I can take that back in an instant,” Adora warned playfully. “But, yeah, a lot of it was because of you. I thought that I could never lo—I mean, like someone again after Huntara, and I associated that horrible feeling with Christmas. Now, I know that’s not true, because of you.” Adora’s heart rate multiplied when she realized she almost said she *loved* Catra. If she had slipped up, that would have been catastrophic—she was pretty sure she was falling in love with Catra, but she couldn’t just *say* that. Their relationship was too fresh.

“I really like you too, Adora,” Catra tenderly replied. “And I’ll only tease you about the Christmas thing once in a while. At least your moms will be happy with me for getting the Grinch out of you. You said they love Christmas, right?”

“They even rival *your* love of Christmas,” Adora replied. “And they couldn’t stand my anti-Christmas spiel this year. I used to love Christmas just as much as they did, you know. It was a shock for them when I started hating it.”

“To be fair, you had a good reason,” Catra conceded, resting her head on Adora’s shoulder. “You don’t have to worry about her anymore, though. And you don’t have to worry about your Christmas being ruined like that again. Lightning doesn’t strike the same place twice.”

Adora chuckled, knowing she was right. She hadn't been this happy in a long time.

Chapter End Notes

chapter 10 will be the christmas carnival! so excited for you all to read that one...

next update: dec 23

Christmas Carnival

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra go to the Christmas Carnival together as their first date. What could spoil the Christmas magic?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Bright Moon Christmas Carnival was marked by two giant candy canes at its entrance, followed by a trail of arches covered in white Christmas lights. In one corner lay an ice skating rink, families laughing as they skated and fell down; a little further, children played various carnival games at booths, victoriously waving around their prizes. A hired Santa sat in his green throne next to the booths, surrounded by shimmering fake wrapped presents. In the center of it all stood a giant Christmas tree—the one Catra had supplied—decked out with an unimaginable amount of lights, ornaments, ribbons, and bows. Of course, a brilliant golden star shone at the top of the tree. It was true Christmas magic.

When Catra and Adora first arrived, they snapped some photos together by the candy canes, Catra planting a kiss on Adora's cheek as they posed. Adora had let her hair down for once, and was wearing a forest green turtleneck with a Christmas wreath brooch. Catra wore a red button-down shirt with black jeans, and had also left her hair down. It was easier to put on a Santa hat that way. Scrolling back through the pictures after they had taken them, Adora had to remark that they looked like a damn good couple. It felt so nice to say that—that they were a couple. It had been worth the wait.

The two of them arrived in the midafternoon, and thus were in the market for some refreshments. They stopped over by Glimmer's bakery's food stand, each grabbing some hot chocolate.

Glimmer was busy preparing orders for the dozens of Bright Moon residents that hovered near the food stand, and didn't have much time to chat, but she was happy to see Catra and Adora together at the carnival.

"I'm glad you two worked things out," Glimmer winked at the new couple, meriting a blush from each of them. "And thanks for testing out the cookies. They've been a total hit. Hopefully I made enough to last the day," she wiped her brow, exhausted. "Can I get you two anything?"

"I'll get a cupcake," Adora replied. Glimmer nodded and handed one to Adora, who took her gloves off to avoid getting frosting on them. "Thanks, Glimmer. You've totally got this, by the way," Adora reassured her. "Either way, the popularity of this stand can't be a bad thing. Your bakery ought to be booming after this, not that people here don't already love it."

"Yeah, I think you're set for a while," Catra added, chuckling. "And thanks to Adora and her great ideas, I think my business is going to be okay, too."

"Thanks, guys. I want to hear all about Adora's ideas soon, but right now, I've got about thirty bazillion carnival goers to attend to right now." Glimmer hastily shoved a lid on top of a to-go cup of hot cocoa.

"Totally understandable. Good luck, Glimmer," Adora waved to her, leaving with Catra to explore other parts of the carnival.

"Up for a little skating?" Catra proposed, gesturing at the makeshift rink.

Adora rolled her eyes fondly. "Not fair, you're so much better than me. The juxtaposition of your skating skills next to mine… let's just say it's going to be embarrassing for one of us." Catra curled her bottom lip, trying to convince Adora. It didn't take long for her to oblige. "Okay, we can skate, but not for too long." Catra clapped her hands and ran for the skates, and once she and

Adora had found skates in their sizes, they stepped onto the ice. Just as before, Catra had to catch a few of Adora's spills, for which she was very grateful. Catra, as she had seen previously, was quite graceful on the ice. Honestly, Adora didn't care what the other skaters thought of her clumsiness; she was only looking at Catra, admiring how carefree yet delicate her skating was.

"When do you have to perform with Bow?" Adora asked Catra as they hung up their skates and changed back into boots.

Catra checked her watch. "The choir he directs is going to be caroling for a while, so not for a few hours. I think we're supposed to perform in the evening."

Adora scanned the rest of the carnival's attractions. "Then we have plenty of time to ride the Ferris wheel," she suggested, grinning.

Catra followed Adora's gaze to the silver and gold Ferris wheel. "Yes, we do. That's always been one of my favorite parts," she told Adora. "But I've never been on it with someone that I'm *with* , you know, so this'll be special."

Adora put her hands to her chest. "Aw, I'm flattered." She was honored to be making these memories with Catra.

Catra took her hand. "Come on, let's go before the line gets too long." Adora happily followed her to the Ferris wheel. It was decorated with blinking lights, made brighter by evening darkness creeping in. This was the winter solstice, after all, the shortest day of the year. The night was young.

The Ferris wheel required a ticket for each person who wished to board it, so Catra ran to the ticket booth to buy a dozen for her and Adora, lest they want to go on the ride again or play one of the other carnival games. Thankfully the line wasn't long enough to prevent them from getting on the ride, so they handed their tickets to the ride operator and sat in one of the passenger cars. Once passengers had filled every car of the Ferris wheel, it slowly

took off. It was slightly rickety; out of fear, Adora made Catra promise not to rock the passenger car. Catra rolled her eyes, stating that was "something only middle schoolers did". Adora didn't want to mention that Huntara used to do that, despite emphatic protests on Adora's part.

When they reached the top of the Ferris wheel, conveniently, it came to a momentary stop. Adora shut her eyes, having been afraid of this happening. "Catra, I can't get stuck up here. Please, I can't."

"We're not going to get *stuck* up here," Catra scoffed, putting an arm around Adora. "It's just a little hitch. This happens all the time. Come on, open your eyes. Just look at how beautiful the town looks from here." Adora abruptly opened her eyes, taking in the sight below her. It was marvelous—granted, she'd rather enjoy it when they weren't stuck at the top—but there was Catra's luminous Christmas tree, and the snow-capped mountains in the distance, and a town of lights and joy.

"It is beautiful," Adora breathed, looking at Catra. The Ferris wheel was still stopped, and it felt as though the two of them were suspended in midair, even if they were supported by the passenger car. At least Adora could take this moment to do something special. She leaned in, closing her eyes when her lips grazed Catra's. She ran her hands through Catra's chestnut tresses, exhaling as Catra kissed her back. The wonderful moment came to an end when the Ferris wheel promptly started up again, Adora jolting when the passenger car whooshed towards the ground. The Ferris wheel made a few more revolutions, and Adora calmly rested her head on Catra's shoulder until it was time for them to exit the passenger car.

"No mistletoe was necessary that time," Adora bantered as they walked to the craft kiosks.

"No, it was not," Catra agreed, shaking her head. "Although, that was a pretty romantic setting. I'll know you really like me if you kiss me at a garbage dump, or something."

"I think that can wait," Adora wrinkled her nose at the notion. "I promise I really like you, Catra." They stopped at a kiosk that sold handmade ornaments. Adora gently picked up a ball-shaped ornament with Santa and his reindeer embossed across its surface. "I'm going to get this for my moms and bring it back home with me. They'll love it."

"What are you doing for Christmas, by the way?" Catra asked.

"I haven't really thought about it since all of our recent developments, but I was planning to go back to New York after leaving Bright Moon. I always spend Christmas with my moms and my grandma," Adora explained. "What about you?"

Catra looked disappointed, and Adora realized that she might have been hoping for an invitation to Christmas dinner. Or was it simply an innocent question? Adora didn't want to overstep. "For the last two Christmases, I've spent the holiday with my 'chosen family' of sorts. Usually just Scorpia and Entrapta, but we have fun. Perfuma might join us too, come to think of it." *Maybe she wants me to join* them *for Christmas? But I can't imagine being without my family for the holidays,* Adora thought. It'd probably be best to talk it over with Catra when they returned to the farm, so she decided to drop the subject for now. After visiting the craft kiosks, they killed time by going on the Ferris wheel again (and thankfully didn't get stuck again). They also played some of the carnival games, and Catra won Adora a reindeer plushie after several tries, despite Adora telling her that she didn't have to use up her tickets on that. She did anyway, but made sure to assert that the machines were rigged, and that was why it had taken her so many tries. Adora wrapped her in a tight hug to thank her for the plushie.

Soon enough, it was time for Catra to perform with Bow. Their instruments were already behind the stage of the pavilion, so all Catra had to do was join Bow to warm up. Adora gave her a thumbs up and said that she would wait in the audience. Before Bow could warm up with Catra, though, he had to finish conducting the Bright Moon High School Varsity Choir, so Adora

was able to see some of that performance too. Bow's conducting was very animated, Adora noticed, and it was fun to see him in his element. His students—about 20 or so of them were on stage—seemed to respond well to him, too. Adora wondered which of them was Frosta; she would bet that it was the short girl with a blue bob, standing in the front row. She was very expressive on stage.

Between the choir and Cyra's performance was the Michael Bublé impersonator. He was very convincing, actually, and Adora wondered how the town had been able to book the act. In his suit and tie, he performed several jazzy Christmas songs, amassing a small army of supporters in the pavilion's audience. Adora hoped the same crowd would stick around to hear Cyra. And when Bow and Catra stepped on stage, perhaps the audience remembered them from years past, because the band was warmly received with a boisterous applause, hoots, and hollers.

"Hey everyone, we're Cyra. Thanks so much for being here tonight," Catra spoke into the microphone, her voice echoing throughout the pavilion. A few more hoots followed from the crowd. She continued, "This is my first performance with Bow in several years, and I'd like to dedicate it to someone special. She's changed my life this week, and I'm so thankful that she came to Bright Moon. Adora, you're the greatest." Catra pointed to the blonde, who blushed as every audience member looked her way. Adora waved to her, her heart overflowing with joy. How had she gotten so lucky?

Catra started singing, "It's the greatest time of year…" Adora figured out that it must have been an original Christmas song. She became engrossed in their performance, swaying along to the music with the rest of the audience. After this song, the applause lasted for at least a minute. Adora loved to see the town so enthusiastic about Catra and Bow's performance. The musical duo launched into a few more songs, singing well-known Christmas songs as well as some more of the band's originals. The crowd even begged them for an encore when they had wrapped up for the night.

“That’s all for tonight, folks,” Bow told the crowd with a grin. “But maybe Cyra will have to reunite for good after tonight.” He looked expectantly at Catra.

“We’ll see,” Catra smirked. “Merry Christmas, Bright Moon.” Adora could hear the audience members chattering around her about how they hoped the band would do future performances. She shook her head, almost laughing; that all depended on if Catra wanted to do it or not.

It didn’t take long for Adora to find Catra and Bow backstage. Glimmer had joined the three of them as well, giving them her congratulations on a successful performance.

“That was awesome, you guys,” Adora beamed. “Bright Moon loved your performance, and so did I.”

“Oh, stop it,” Catra blushed. “That was just a one-time thing, by the way. It was fun to revive my music career, but I think I’ll put it to rest now.”

“Yeah, sure,” Bow scoffed, doubtful. “Anyway, do you guys wanna celebrate our performance with some mulled wine?”

“That sounds great,” Adora nodded. “I’m up for it if everyone else is.” Catra and Glimmer enthusiastically agreed, so the four of them started walking over to the mulled wine station. Many a passersby stopped Bow and Catra along the way, commenting on their lovely performance.

The night was beginning to grow even colder than it had already been, so Adora fished in her pocket for her gloves, only to find that they were missing. “Oh, no,” she sighed, “My gloves are gone… I must have left them over where we got our food, since I took them off to eat a cupcake.”

“You know, I thought I saw some gloves over there,” Glimmer told her. “Sorry, it didn’t occur to me that they were yours.”

"No big deal. I'll go get them alone. Just save me a spot in line for that mulled wine," Adora replied.

"Are you sure? I can come with," Catra offered, supportively touching Adora's arm.

"No, don't worry about it. I'll just be a minute anyway," Adora assured her calmly. Briskly, she began walking towards the food station, passing the giant Christmas tree on the way. She was sure she knew where she had left the gloves, and only hoped that no one had moved them. But while she was walking, she was stopped by someone tapping on her shoulder. She whipped around to face them, thinking maybe it was Catra, but it wasn't. In fact, she thought she was hallucinating the person she saw in front of her.

" *Huntara?* " Adora gasped, gaping at the sight of her ex-girlfriend/almost-fiancée. How could she be here, right now, in Bright Moon?

"Adora," Huntara stared back. She didn't look much different than she had on the night she left Adora. Her long, white-blonde hair was tied into a ponytail, and was shaved on the sides. And she still towered over Adora, of course. Adora couldn't even process the fact that this woman—the woman who rejected her proposal before she could even propose, the woman who she hadn't seen in almost a year—stood in front of her now. Huntara cleared her throat. "It's really nice to see you, Adora. I've missed you so much."

"H-how did you even know I was here?" Adora stammered, her heart racing.

"I have my ways," Huntara shrugged. "I knew you were in Bright Moon, and it wasn't hard to figure out that you'd be at the town's biggest event of the year."

But how did she know I was in Bright Moon? Adora racked her brain. *Did my moms tell her? No, they never would have betrayed*

me like that… Suddenly, she realized there was one person Huntara could have easily asked. *Double Trouble.* Adora knew Huntara had their number, as Adora had introduced the two of them a couple years ago. Double Trouble either thought they were being helpful to Adora by giving Huntara that information, or the exact opposite. Either way, Adora was fuming. "Double Trouble told you I was here, didn't they?"

"Yes, but don't be mad at them," Huntara tried to protest. "I had to get in touch with you, Adora. I've been so lost without you, you don't even understand."

"But I texted you—" Adora started, but Huntara promptly interrupted.

"It's okay, Adora, you don't have to pretend anymore. I know you've been hurting without me, too. My friends said you were still devastated when they saw you a couple months after the breakup. But I'm here to make things right."

"What are you…" Before Adora could react, Huntara was on one knee, opening a little black box with a sizable diamond ring at its center. Adora gasped, in complete disbelief. Huntara coming to Bright Moon was one thing—her proposing was completely another.

"I wasn't ready to commit to you before, Adora, but I'll never make that mistake again. We're so right together, Adora. Will you marry me?" Huntara took Adora's hand, and Adora was too stunned to immediately pull it away. She was shocked, her jaw still on the floor. She looked around her, noticing that some of the carnival goers had started to gather, watching the spectacle. Even worse, Catra was one of them. She must have gotten worried after Adora didn't come back from retrieving her gloves. Adora made direct eye contact with her, but Catra shook her head, pushing through the crowd and walking away. Adora needed to go after her, but first, she had to clear things up with Huntara.

"You're too late, Huntara," Adora spat, ripping her hand from Huntara's grasp. Huntara stayed on her knee, clearly too shocked to move. Adora knew that everyone was still watching them, but she had to make sure Huntara knew that they were done. "If you had actually paid attention to what I texted you, you'd know that I'm happy. I've moved on. In fact, there's someone else—here, in Bright Moon—that I really care about. And thanks to this hamfisted proposal, she probably thinks that I want to be with *you* now."

Huntara finally stood up, closing the ring box and putting it away. "Oh, Adora, I'm so sorry… I shouldn't have come here. My friends warned me not to. I just really wanted to make things right with you."

"You should have listened to your friends," Adora set her jaw. "I'm sorry that things didn't work out between us, but it's too late to make things right now."

"You're right." Huntara hung her head low. "I just wanted to try."

Adora really did feel bad for rejecting her proposal—hell, she sort of knew how it felt—but nothing about this was right. Her story with Huntara had ended, and her story with Catra had just begun. "I hope you find what you're looking for, Huntara. I've got to go find someone important to me."

Adora pushed through the crowd, trying to catch up to Catra without stepping on any toes. Once she had gotten past the swarm of people, she scanned the entire carnival grounds, looking for any sign of Catra. She couldn't find her anywhere. Her worst fears were confirmed true—that Catra had misinterpreted what she saw. What if she even thought that Adora had accepted Huntara's stupid proposal? No, she had to know that Adora wouldn't say "yes" to that… she had to. Maybe Adora could still find Bow and Glimmer. She power-walked to the mulled wine kiosk, and sure enough, they were standing there with wine in hand.

“Oh, hey, Adora. We thought Catra went to go get you. Where is she?” Bow asked, sipping his wine.

“She did. But now she’s gone,” Adora replied, trying to catch her breath.

“What do you mean, ‘she’s gone?’” Glimmer repeated with a furrowed brow. “Is she okay?”

“Yes, sort of. Well, not really,” Adora attempted to explain, but she was in a frenzy. “My ex-girlfriend, Huntara, sort of showed up and proposed to me and Catra saw it.”

“Yikes, that’s gnarly,” Bow cringed. “Well, you said ‘no’, didn’t you?”

“Of *course* I did,” Adora confirmed emphatically. “But she didn’t see that happen, because she stormed off. I’m pretty sure she thinks that I want Huntara back. Huntara was holding my hands, and I didn’t immediately push her away, so it probably looked bad…” Adora put her head in her hands in desperation. She just had to find a way to clear this up with Catra.

“Well, you just need to explain everything, then,” Glimmer said matter-of-factly. “Where’s Catra?”

“I’m pretty sure she’s left the carnival grounds entirely. I looked everywhere for her.” Adora’s tears threatened to spill over. What a mess this was, to end such an incredible day with Catra. “I don’t even know how I’m going to get back to the farm. She drove me here.”

“Don’t worry. We’ll drive you home,” Bow reassuringly put a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “It’s going to be all right, Adora.”

Adora didn’t have any way of knowing if that was true.

Glimmer and Bow gave Adora a ride back to the farm in their truck. Adora's hands shook for the duration of the car ride; what if Catra wouldn't be there? She thanked them after they dropped her off, and waved goodbye to them. They made her promise to update them as the situation transpired, and told her that they'd help her if she needed it. Adora was grateful to have friends like them.

Adora hastened to the main house, praying that Catra would be there so they could simply *talk* . A note on the door greeted her first, though.

Adora,

If you're reading this, I'm staying with a friend right now. Just need to clear my head right now. Above all, I want you to be happy; you should do what your heart wants. I won't stand in the way of that.

-Catra

Oh, no… she really *did* believe that Adora wanted Huntara over her. How could she think Adora would abandon her like that? Adora frantically pulled out her phone and tried to call Catra, to no avail. She texted her a few times, too, begging her to come home so they could talk. It was no use. Catra didn't want to talk to Adora right now.

Maybe there was one place Adora could check for answers, though… It was worth a try. She got in her Subaru and drove to the inn, praying that Scorpia would be there. At least it was across the street, so the drive only took a minute. Catra probably would have confided in her best friend, right? She betted that Scorpia would know something.

Luckily, Scorpia indeed stood at the inn's front desk. Adora wasted no time in getting to her, sprinting to the front. "Hi, Scorpia. I was wondering if—"

"Yes, I know where Catra is. No, I won't tell you," Scorpia crossed her arms firmly. "Shouldn't you be with your fiancée, anyway?"

"She's not my fiancée," Adora gritted her teeth. "I want Catra, not her. Please, Scorpia, there's been a huge misunderstanding. I know Catra's staying at your place, can you just tell me where to go so we can talk?"

Scorpia critically looked her over. "I don't know. She seemed really hurt, and I don't want you to make things worse." She took a deep breath, "She thought it was a bad sign that you didn't say you wanted to spend Christmas with her." *I was right, she* was *upset about that,* Adora realized. "And she thinks you were blowing smoke about wanting to work at the farm. Since you haven't formally quit your job at Horde Realty yet, she was worried that… well, that maybe… Never mind, I've said too much."

"What, Scorpia?"

"That this was all just an elaborate ploy to get her to sell the farm."

"Oh my God, she's got it all wrong. I'd never do that to her. I just need to explain everything. Why would she even think that?"

Scorpia sighed, looking away from Adora. "Catra's been hurt and abandoned a lot of times in her life. That's why she reacted so strongly to this. I… You know I've been rooting for the two of you this whole time, and I still am. That's why I think you should give her some time to mull things over. This is a fresh wound for her. But I'll tell you what." Scorpia leaned over the front desk, lowering her voice. "The inn is throwing our annual ugly Christmas sweater party tomorrow. It starts at 6 p.m., and Catra *may or may not* be there. If you find a way to show her how much you care about her, you might have a chance of saving things."

“Thank you, Scorpia,” Adora clasped her hands together. “I do care about her. So, so, much. And I’m going to get her back.”

She *would* get Catra back, whatever it took.

Chapter End Notes

and here you thought this was just going to be a fluff chapter... remember, even hallmark movies have some angst!

i have been thoroughly enjoying all of your comments, keep it up :)

next update: dec 25

Make the Yuletide...

Chapter Summary

> Adora hatches a plan to get Catra back at the ugly Christmas sweater party. Will she succeed, or will she have to leave Bright Moon with her bags and a broken heart?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora had her work cut out if she wanted to make an impression at the Etherian's ugly Christmas sweater party. Well, not just an impression, but a gesture that would show Catra how much she cared for her. She felt her chest throb every time she remembered what Scorpia had told her the night before. Catra believed there was a chance that Adora was using her, that Adora had still been secretly pining for Huntara before the proposal. She couldn't have been more wrong, though—seeing Huntara proved to Adora that she had no lingering romantic feelings in that arena. She only had eyes for Catra now, and was pretty sure that had been the case since the second she laid eyes on the farmer.

Adora's first order of business was actually finding an ugly Christmas sweater to wear at the party. She didn't know where to look for one in Bright Moon, and it was obviously too late to simply order one online; maybe this was for the best, though. A personalized, homemade sweater would be much more impressive than some store-bought one.

The only problem: Adora wasn't a clothing design master by any means. She could hardly operate a sewing machine, not that she even had access to one at the farm. (She was pretty sure Catra didn't have one, but she couldn't exactly *ask* . This was supposed to be a surprise, and besides, she and Catra weren't on "ask-about-sewing-machine" terms at the moment.) There was one other person, however, that she suspected she could ask for help.

“Hey, Perfuma,” Adora greeted the art teacher over the phone. Sure, Perfuma was dating Catra’s best friend, but she wasn’t completely entangled in the situation. She was mostly friends with Catra because of Scorpia. and Adora doubted that Perfuma would have any qualms about aiding her. “I hope you’re not too busy right now. I was wondering if you could help me out with something.”

“Sure, what’s up?” Perfuma asked, chipper as always.

“I’m going to that ugly Christmas sweater party tonight—I’m sure you’ll be there too—and I really could use your help in making a custom sweater. You’re probably the most adept person in the field of visual arts that I know here, and it’s really important that I have a good sweater for the party. My relationship with Catra kind of depends on the party, actually.” Adora tried not to sound too desperate, but it was a futile attempt.

“Ooh, that sounds like fun!” Perfuma squealed. “I made a custom ugly Christmas sweater for myself this year, so I have some materials left over. Plus, some various other fabrics, and a sewing machine. I need to finish up some things at the school, so you can come over in a few hours. I’ll text you when I’m ready.”

“Thank you *so* much, Perfuma. You don’t know how much of a big help this is.”

“Hey, any time. I don’t know all of the details of what happened between you and Catra, but you’re great together. I hope everything works out for the best.”

Adora smiled faintly. She had to pull this off tonight, to prove to Catra that her insecurities about their relationship were completely unfounded. “I hope so, too.”

While waiting for Perfuma to wrap up her responsibilities at the high school, Adora needed to take the time to plan something else. The ugly Christmas sweater was only one component of her plan to get Catra back. Now, she would focus on demonstrating to

Catra that she meant business… about their business. In other words, Adora was ready to go all-in with the business ideas she had pitched to Catra the other day. She had to make another call.

"Bow? I'm planning something big for tonight, on Catra's farm, and I think you're the person to call…"

The interior of Perfuma's house was pretty much what Adora would have expected. Artwork covered every corner of the house, and she assumed that most of it was made by Perfuma. Clearly, she was talented. However, Adora was surprised to see so many plants in the house: ferns, succulents, and poinsettias, along with a Christmas tree, of course. Hope, being a florist and all, would have loved to see it.

Perfuma noticed Adora checking out all of her plants. "Being a plant mom is my secondary passion, behind art. Taking care of them requires a surprising amount of discipline, actually. It calms me, though."

"You seem to be doing a great job," Adora commented as Perfuma led her to her work room. "So, do you have experience with clothing design? I mean, I knew you were an artist, but I'm not sure what your specialty is."

"I'm mostly a painter, but Bright Moon High has a fashion design class. I'm the only one qualified to teach it," Perfuma explained. "I didn't go to school for fashion, specifically, but I've dabbled in it. And because I teach the class, I have a lot of fabrics and materials lying around."

"Thanks for letting me use them, by the way." Adora smiled gratefully.

"No problem! I probably wouldn't have used all of these, anyway. So what are you envisioning for your Christmas sweater?" Perfuma asked Adora, laying several types of tulle, sequins, bulbs, and other knick knacks on the table of her work room.

"I want to make something… meaningful. As meaningful as a Christmas sweater can be." Adora pulled a plain white and red sweater out of her bag; she had brought it with her to Bright Moon. It was more convenient to zhuzh up something she already owned, anyway. "We can add some things to this sweater. Maybe some things that represent my relationship with Catra."

"*Awww*, that's so romantic," Perfuma cooed, her eyes lighting up. "By the way, Scorpia filled me in on what happened. I hope you don't mind. Your ex, coming to Bright Moon… that's crazy."

"No, I don't mind her telling you. Now I don't have to explain the situation to another person. And, yeah… it's pretty wild. I was ready to move on, you know? I had already moved on, really. Catra's the person I care about."

"I can tell. I think *everyone* can tell. It'll be okay, Adora." Perfuma patted Adora's shoulder to comfort her.

"Thanks, Perfuma. Will you distract me by showing me what's on your ugly Christmas sweater?" Adora tried not to let doubt and worry creep in, but both of those were about to beat her if she didn't think about something else besides… well, everything that could possibly go wrong tonight.

"Sure thing! It's in my closet, I'll go get it." Perfuma briefly left and returned with a bright green sweater, adorned with silver tinsel and little red pom-poms that were supposed to be holly berries.

"Wow, Perfuma, that's hardly even ugly," Adora admired the sweater. "I mean, it's just cute."

"That's the point! And, with my help, your sweater can look like this too. I promise Catra will be impressed." Perfuma gave Adora

finger guns, making her chuckle.

With some luck, the sweater—and the other secret part of Adora's plan—would be enough to convince Catra that Adora only had eyes for her. Adora checked her watch; in a few hours, it would be showtime. She could only hope that everything would fall into place.

Adora showed up to the Etherian's ugly Christmas sweater party fashionably late. She thought it would be odd to arrive right at 6. Further, she had to take a good hour to psych herself up. It was intimidating, but whatever happened here, tonight, would determine the future of her and Catra.

Cars and trucks filled the inn's parking lot; Adora doubted the party would have the turnout of the Christmas Carnival, nor did the inn have the capacity to handle that amount of people, but it was certainly a shindig. When Adora walked through the doors, she couldn't help but wistfully think of the first time she came here—the day she met Catra. Scorpia was there to greet her, to boot, albeit not at the front desk this time. She was stationed outside of a large party room, both of its ornate doors open, and Adora could catch a glimpse of its inside. Red and green ribbons were wrapped around the pillars, and the sounds of Christmas music streamed into the inn lobby.

"Adora, you came," Scorpia raised her eyebrows, looking half-surprised to see Adora there. She gave Adora's ugly Christmas sweater a once-over. "And you showed up in style."

Adora gave her a cordial nod. "I wouldn't have missed it for the world."

"Glad to hear it. If you're looking for Catra, she's in here somewhere. I just saw her, but I lost sight of her…" Scorpia bit her

lip, trying to find Catra, but then shrugged at Adora. "I doubt she left, she must be in the middle of the crowd."

“It’s all right, Scorpia. She’ll turn up. Thanks for what you’ve already done to help me.” Adora walked into the inn’s event room, across its maroon carpeting, noticing the flamboyant Christmas sweaters at every turn. Many of them were store-bought, but some of them looked to be handcrafted, like Adora’s. Attempting to not get distracted by all of the sweaters, she scanned the party, looking for the woman for whom she had shown up. There were too many people packed into the inn’s small event room to spot Catra right away.

At any rate, Adora needed to say what she had been planning to say. In the party room, she spotted just the way to do it. She walked to the front of the room, where there stood a microphone next to a Christmas tree. In fact, it was probably the one she had seen Catra bring in on the day they met. She smiled at the memory, but then refocused on what she had come to the party to do.

“Ahem,” Adora tapped on the microphone, slowly but surely garnering the attention of the room. “I-I hope everyone’s having a good night.” She quickly realized she sounded like a hotel lounge singer between songs and decided to switch gears. “I won’t waste your time. I’m here because there’s someone I really care about in this room right now, and she has to know that. Over the last eleven days, I’ve had the opportunity to stay on her farm. After getting to know her, I have to tell you, there’s no one in the world like her. She’s intelligent, hilarious, talented, and she has a beautiful soul.” Adora stopped to take a deep breath, aware of the people in the other party attendees whispering to each other and staring at Adora. But she looked past them, making eye contact with Catra, whose expression Adora couldn’t read. She stood next to Entrapta, a champagne flute in her hand. She was frozen as she watched Adora.

Adora gulped, mustering the courage to continue. She addressed Catra directly now. “I’ve only known you for eleven days, Catra,

but I've never connected with anyone else in my life like I've connected with you. When I was still reeling from the worst heartbreak of my life, *you* made me realize that happiness was possible again. When I was scarred from the events of last Christmas, *you* showed me just how magical Christmastime can be. And when I was jaded from years of living in the big city, ignoring the small things in life, *you* helped me slow down and take it all in. That's why you need to know that you're the one who matters most to me. Not anyone else." Adora's hands shook like leaves, but she grasped the bottom of her sweater and stretched it out for the crowd to see. She spotted Perfuma standing next to Scorpia, and both gave Adora a thumbs up. "With a little help from a friend, I specially made this sweater for this party tonight. It's our story, Catra. There's a Christmas tree—I think we all know why that's there." Adora hoped a joke about Catra's profession would lighten the mood, and thankfully, the party attendees (including Catra) responded with laughter. "And the snowflake represents a snowball fight. I think you remember what that means for us, Catra." Adora knew she was giving this speech in front of dozens, but she wanted to keep some things just between herself and Catra. It was more special that way. Catra gave her a subtle smile in return. Adora continued, "And, finally, mistletoe. Because we might not have known that we both liked each other without it." At that reference, Catra's mouth curved into a wide grin. Adora's heart fluttered at the triumph of getting Catra to smile—to *really* smile. Adora decided to take a leap of faith; she had already poured out her heart in front of everyone, why not give them the whole truth? "I love you, Catra. I always will."

It felt as though the entire room was holding its collective breath in waiting for Catra to respond. Dead silence. Catra didn't say anything at first; she walked up to the microphone, where Adora stood, and looked directly at her. "I love you too, Adora." The crowd erupted into cheers and applause when Catra pulled Adora in for a kiss, her hand supporting the small of Adora's back as she dipped her. Everyone was watching, but Adora, caught up in the moment, only focused on Catra. She had worried that she'd never

be this close to Catra again, that what they had was lost, but thankfully those fears were baseless.

When they pulled away, Adora finally looked back at the crowd. Everyone seemed to be so happy for the two of them, gazing adoringly at the couple. Adora and Catra gazed at each other and giggled, realizing what a spectacle this had all been. Catra playfully whispered in her ear, "You show-off, how am I ever going to top this grand declaration of love?"

Adora smirked, whispering back, "You'll need to think of something really good, because my spiel actually isn't done yet." She leaned in closer to the microphone again, addressing the audience. "One more thing, everyone. At 10 p.m., Driluth Farms is hosting its first ever 'Music Among the Trees' concert. I hope you all can make it, because we've got a great lineup. Yes, the Michael Bublé impersonator will be there." A few party goers hooted at that last announcement. Adora stepped away from the mic and looked at Catra, waiting for her to react.

Catra's mouth dropped in surprise, but she didn't seem upset. "You organized a concert at the farm? Adora, that's amazing. How busy have you been today?"

"Although I did have some help… I've been *very* busy." Adora wiped her brow in exhaustion. "It was worth it, though. You'll always be worth it to me."

Adora could have sworn that Catra started to tear up. "How did I get so lucky?"

While Adora dealt with the ugly Christmas sweater situation, Bow and Glimmer had worked tirelessly to set up the concert back at the farm. Bow set up some basic sound equipment outside, on an emptier stretch of land where trees were sparse. There would be

plenty of room for concert goers to gather and watch the performers. Christmas lights and some electric torches illuminated the makeshift stage. The first performer on stage was the Michael Bublé impersonator. Apparently his name was Sea Hawk in real life, and Adora couldn't believe that Bow had been able to book him for this event, since many of the other performers were Bright Moon High School students. Sea Hawk's crooning instantly drew in the audience members who were starting to trickle onto the farm. Adora was delighted to see that after only a few minutes, 'Music Among the Trees' had gained a decently-sized crowd. Entry was free for this inaugural concert, but Bow was taking donations for the farm at the entrance. Adora had a feeling that Bright Moon's residents would want to support Catra and the beloved farm, and thus that they might be generous in their donations.

"How did you pull this off?" Catra asked Adora incredulously, taking in the sight in front of her. "I can't believe we actually have live music on *my* farm. This is like, a dream come true."

"Bow booked the acts and set up the sound equipment. It was hard to get it all done today, but I wanted to do it for you, because I can't wait to be your project manager." Adora pulled Catra in by her waist, kissing her on the cheek. "Hopefully, the next time we do one of these, there'll be an actual stage. And it'll be better organized. But I hope you're happy with what we were able to throw together tonight."

"I *love* what you've done tonight," Catra beamed, but then became more serious. "Um, Adora… I'm sorry about the way I acted, or rather reacted, last night. When I saw you with Huntara, I sort of panicked. I've never been with someone as great as you, and I guess I was so worried I'd lose you that I pushed you away before that could happen. But you are one of the best things that's ever happened to me, Adora, and tonight you've shown me how beautiful your heart is."

"Now you're going to make me cry," Adora chuckled, but joyful tears truly were starting to creep in. "I don't want to lose you either, Catra."

Catra gently shook her head. “You won’t. I love you so much.”

“I love you, too.” Adora leaned her head on Catra’s. The two of them stayed like that for a moment, wholly comfortable in each other’s presence. The audience’s chatter and cheers were lively, but Catra and Adora stayed quiet, simply thankful that they were back together again.

“There’s one more thing,” Adora broke the silence. Catra curiously looked over at her. “I want you to come home with me for Christmas. To New York. I can’t imagine spending the holiday without you, and I really want you to meet my moms. What do you say?”

“I’d love to. That sounds amazing. ” Catra, touched by the offer, accepted eagerly. “But I have sort of an idea for Christmas Eve Eve.” Adora raised an eyebrow quizzically. “You know, December twenty-third,” Catra clarified.

“What’s that?” Adora asked.

“Like I said, I always do Christmas with my chosen family, Entrapta and Scorpia. I was hoping that we could have a pre-Christmas dinner on the twenty-third. We could invite Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma too. That way we could do a friends’ Christmas gathering even though I’m coming with you to New York.”

“That’s a great idea,” Adora happily squeezed Catra’s hand. “Would we host?”

“I always do,” Catra replied. “I hope you’ll help me cook.”

Adora couldn’t stifle a laugh. “Ha! I’m useless in the kitchen, but I can certainly try.” Her moms still did most of the cooking on Christmas, to this day.

“We *miiiight* have to work on that for the future. But for now, I’ll just be happy to be with you, Adora.”

“And I with you, Catra.”

"So... is the lineup too packed, or can I sign up for a set at the last minute?" Catra grinned devilishly, making Adora gasp.

"You really want to sing? Without someone asking you to do it? Never thought I'd see the day. I'm sure Bow can arrange something." Adora couldn't hold back her enthusiasm.

"Hey, don't push it, or I'll make you sing with me."

"Believe me, *no one* wants to hear that," Adora chuckled fondly.

All jokes aside, Adora had never felt so warm, even in the cold of December. If she hadn’t known for sure that she loved Catra before (which, in all honesty, was impossible after that snowball fight), she knew it now, a million times over.

Chapter End Notes

merry christmas! here's my present to you... chapter 11 :)

final chapter out dec 28. i can't believe this story is almost done... this update schedule has been tight, but it's been so much fun to write and post the fic.

The Twelfth Day of Catra

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora spend their first Christmas together. (Plus a flash-forward to a future Christmas).

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

On the morning of the twenty-third, Adora and Catra flurried around the house, hastening to prepare for the Friendmas celebration they'd be hosting that night. Bow, Glimmer, Entrapta, Scorpia, and Perfuma were all on the guest list, so there would be more people than Catra usually hosted for Friendmas. She and Adora spent much of the day tending to the giant turkey in the oven, as well as tidying up the place. They also went into town and got a couple small gifts for a white elephant gift exchange, a longtime tradition of Catra and her friends. By early evening, everything was in order—though Catra's sautéed vegetables nearly burned on the stove due to the fact that she and Adora got distracted by kissing each other. After dealing with so much tension and so many pent-up feelings over the last twelve days, it was hard for them to stay apart from one another. Luckily, Catra was able to salvage the vegetables, and the mishap wasn't noticeable in their taste.

Eventually, the guests started to trickle into Catra's house, all with small wrapped gifts in hand for the white elephant exchange. (Glimmer also presented a chocolate chip cheesecake at the door, which was very much welcomed by everyone in the house.) All of the friends were so glad to see Catra and Adora together, and Scorpia continuously joked that the couple should credit her for her efforts in matchmaking. Not to mention, Scorpia was the one who had encouraged Catra to let Adora stay at her farm when she first arrived in Bright Moon. Without that push, who knew what would have become of Catra and Adora's relationship?

"I didn't appreciate your *tactics* at first, Scorpia," Catra told her with a glint in her eye as they drank some post-dinner coffee at the dining room table, "but I think it's clear that it turned out for the best." She reached out for Adora's hand on the table. The blonde, who sat next to her, happily took it.

"I knew it would," Scorpia pumped her fist in the air. "Besides, it was the least I could do. You know, after you let me have the bonfire here. You helped bring me and Perfuma together." Scorpia smiled at her girlfriend, who started to blush.

"Well, I also owe you two a 'thank you' for helping me reconnect with Catra yesterday," Adora gestured to Scorpia and Perfuma. "That ugly Christmas sweater Perfuma and I designed… It was the *pièce de résistance* . Plus, I couldn't have planned that concert without Bow's help." Adora cleared her throat and held up her glass of wine, "So… I'd like to toast to all of the friends I've made here in Bright Moon. You've all been so welcoming and supportive, and that's part of the reason why I'm going to be sticking around here for a while." Everyone clinked each other's glasses, and took a sip of their respective drinks.

"Wait, you're not going back to New York?" Bow asked, taking a bite of the cheesecake.

"Nope," Adora popped the "p". She looked over at Catra, who was the main reason she'd be staying in Bright Moon, and the farmer's lips curved upwards when she caught Adora's glance. "Well, Catra and I will be going back tomorrow to visit my family for Christmas, but I won't be living there anymore. I've decided to leave my real estate firm. When we drive to New York tomorrow, I'll make it official. And, starting in January, I'm going to be Driluth Farms' new project manager. Last night's concert was only the beginning."

Each of the guests clapped at Adora's announcement. Catra lovingly added, "And I couldn't be luckier that she's going to work with me."

“Adora’s dating the boss, eh?” Scorpia teased. She gave Adora a high five.

Catra laughed along with her. “I guess it’s a little unprofessional that Adora’s my girlfriend, given that I’m the boss here… which also is kind of ironic considering ‘professionalism’ kept us from confessing our feelings…” Her quip garnered an affectionate eye roll from Adora, but Adora was primarily focused on the swell in her heart that resulted from Catra calling her “my girlfriend”. It was pretty obvious that she was, indeed, Catra’s girlfriend; still, she didn’t think she had heard Catra call her that in front of people until now. It was exhilarating. Catra continued, “But I don’t really see it that way. We’re in this thing together.”

“At least you can’t get fired, Catra,” Entrapta chuckled, “unless the Pennsylvania Christmas Tree Farm Association just passed a new law about tree farmers dating their project managers that I didn’t know about.” She stopped for a moment, seriously considering the concept.

“We’ll have to check on that, but I have a feeling it’s all right. Either way, I’m just really excited to be here,” Adora beamed, her voice genuine. “Anyway, now that we’re pretty much done with dinner, how about our gift exchange?”

The guests nodded enthusiastically at Adora’s suggestion. Everyone had placed their gifts underneath the Christmas tree in Catra’s living room, so the party moved there for the exchange. They had great fun picking out gifts—mostly festive, fun doodads—and swapping them. But at the end of the exchange, Catra pulled Adora aside to give her a gift of her own. The two of them excused themselves from their guests, telling them they would be right back, and Catra led Adora upstairs.

“I know it’s not Christmas yet, but there’s something I want to give you right now.” Catra produced a small jewelry box from her vanity, placing it in Adora’s hand. Adora examined the box, turning it over and imagining its contents, then excitedly opened it. Inside was a shining silver locket in the shape of a heart. Adora took it

out of the box and dangled it in the air, admiring it as it caught the light.

"This is beautiful," Adora gasped in awe, her heart melting. "When did you find the time to get this?"

"Remember how, earlier today, we split up to cover more ground when we went shopping for our white elephant gifts in town? Well, I slipped into the jewelry store without you noticing," Catra explained, evidently proud that she had been able to stealthily buy Adora the gift.

"Wow, I don't know what to say, except… Thank you so much, Catra. Will you help me put it on?" Adora ran her thumb over the silver of the necklace.

"Of course, but let me show you something before you do," Catra pointed at the locket, then gently opened it up. Inside of the locket was a tiny picture of Catra kissing Adora's cheek—one of the pictures they had taken at the Christmas Carnival. "I also made another quick stop today to get this photo printed out."

"Catra, this is wonderful. I'm going to wear this all the time, I love it so much. It's like I'm carrying a piece of us around all the time." Adora held her hair out of the way so that Catra could clasp the locket around her neck. "And since you gave me an early present, I'm going to return the favor. We'll have to go to the guest house to get it, though."

Catra fluttered her fingers in anticipation. "Ooh, what could it be?"

"You'll see," Adora raised her eyebrows. They walked outside, passing rows of trees, and made their way to the guest house. Once inside, Adora reached under her bed and retrieved a medium-sized box. "Go ahead, open it," she urged Catra.

Catra eagerly took the lid off the box, freezing when she saw what was inside. "You got me new ice skates? Thank you for this." Catra threw her arms around Adora in appreciation. "Hey, wait… when did *you* have the time to get these?"

"Let's just say you weren't the only one who was busy getting gifts today," Adora answered smugly. "You're so good at skating, I figured you could use some new skates."

"Adora… In case you didn't know it already, I love you." Catra took both of Adora's hands, earnestly gazing at her.

Adora kissed Catra on her nose. "I love you too, Catra."

Catra and Adora drove into New York City fairly early on Christmas Eve. The drive wasn't too long, so they made it to the city before noon. Before going to Mara and Hope's house, though, there was something Adora needed to do first. She had to formally quit her job at Horde Realty. She knew it would feel as though a weight had been lifted from her shoulders, once she had ripped off the Band-Aid. But finally severing that tie was going to be strange; she had dedicated five years of her life to her job at the firm.

It was a holiday, but Adora had no doubt that Hordak would be in his office today. He didn't strike her as the type to take much time off before Christmas. Occasionally, as Adora remembered from years past, he didn't even let his employees take off the entirety of Christmas Eve. At any rate, at least him working today would mean that she could have a face-to-face conversation with him about leaving her job. She thought quitting her job over the phone would be a terrible look, even if it would save the time and discomfort of doing it in person.

So, for the last time ever, Adora took the elevator up to the 17th floor, where she knew she'd find Hordak. Hordak's secretary led her to his office—sure enough, he was working on Christmas Eve. Adora took a deep breath and knocked on the door. This was it.

"Come in," Hordak bellowed irritably, presumably from his desk. Adora opened the door, stiffening once she saw him. He glared at

her, but motioned for her to sit down. “Adora, I hope you’re here to tell me that Ms. Driluth signed those papers.”

“I’m… afraid not,” Adora broke the news, biting her lip. Hordak’s glare turned more fiery, but he said nothing. Adora straightened herself in her chair, exuding confidence. “She didn’t sell the farm, nor does she need to. Her business is going to make it.”

“This is *very* distressing news,” Hordak spat, and Adora imagined steam coming out of his ears. That was how infuriated he was. “Well, you know what this means, Adora. No promotion. In fact, with the lack of communication I received from your end, I may have to re-evaluate your *current* role at this firm.” He finished his spiel with a small “hmph” for good measure.

“No need,” Adora replied calmly. “I’ve found a new job. Effective immediately, I no longer work for you.” *Man, that felt so good to say,* Adora thought, trying to suppress her smirk.

“Come again?” Hordak leaned forward, as if he hadn’t heard her. But he had, and was vexed. “And, pray tell, where do you work now?”

“Driluth Farms.” Adora dropped that bit of information as nonchalantly as possible, watching Hordak silently implode. “I’m going to be Ms. Driluth’s new project manager.”

“How… lovely,” Hordak responded through gritted teeth. “And I suppose you wouldn’t, by chance, reconsider that poor decision?” Maybe his threats of sacking Adora had been empty, because it certainly seemed like he was asking her to stay.

“Oh, there’s no chance,” Adora retorted. “I don’t regret the time I’ve spent working at Horde Realty, but it’s time for me to explore other avenues. In fact, I’ll gather my things from my desk now. Merry Christmas, Hordak, and Happy New Year.” Before Hordak could respond, Adora stood up, dusted herself off, and shut the door behind her. Thankfully, she’d never have to see that man again.

With her box of things and a smile, Adora returned to the car, where Catra had been waiting. “That was quick,” Catra commented, eyeing Adora’s box. “How’d it go?”

“It was oddly freeing,” Adora remarked, placing her box in the backseat area. “I’m glad that chapter of my life is over. Let’s go see my family.”

“Catra, it’s so wonderful to meet you!” Mara practically tackled Catra into a hug as soon as she stepped through the door. “We’ve heard so much about you from Adora. Here, let me take your bags.” Adora shot her mom the “stop-embarrassing-me” glance, but it was futile. After the ugly Christmas sweater party and before Friendmas, Adora had called her moms to fill them in on her relationship with Catra, as well as to ask if Catra could come there for Christmas Eve and Christmas. Of course, the answer was an emphatic “yes”, as her moms were thrilled that Adora had found someone like Catra. After last year’s heartbreak with Huntara, they were especially thrilled to see Adora finding love again. Mara’s and Hope’s only grief was that Adora would soon be moving to Pennsylvania, but Adora reminded them that the drive was only a few hours. She could visit them each weekend if she wanted to. That tidbit of information did well to placate them.

Once Mara had finally let Catra go, Hope greeted her with a hug as well. “Nice to meet you, Catra. Adora said that you love Christmas just as much as we do, and I have to admit, that already makes me like you more.”

“It’s great to meet you guys as well,” Catra replied shyly. At the mention of their love of Christmas, she took a gander at the abundance of festive decorations covering the house, visibly impressed. “And Adora’s right, I do love Christmas. Comes with the territory of being a Christmas tree farmer.”

"Catra got me back into the Christmas spirit, if you can believe that," Adora gushed, playing with her locket. The weight of it on her chest was ever-comforting. "I entered her farm as Scrooge and left it as… Scrooge at the end of the story."

"And thank goodness for that, because I don't think we could have handled another year of Adora's Christmas-related moping," Hope sighed in relief. "But even if you were a Grinch, Catra, we'd still be glad to have you here." Catra blushed at Hope's kind words.

"She-Ra? Is that you?" An older voice croaked from the kitchen. Razz emerged, walking in with her cane, and Adora leaned down to give her a hug.

"It's Adora, Grandma Razz," Adora gently reminded her. "I missed you a lot. This is my girlfriend, Catra."

"Hello, I'm Catra. It's nice to meet you, Razz."

"Oh, hello, dearie!" Razz absorbed Catra into her hug with Adora. "I can tell you're the nicest one She-Ra's brought home yet. Don't ask me why, I just have a sense for these things."

"Well… Thank you. I guess that's the goal," Catra chuckled fondly. "By the way," she addressed all of Adora's family, "I really appreciate you letting me spend Christmas here. I don't mean to impose, or anything. But it's been years since I've had a… *nice* family Christmas, and I'm really excited to spend it with all of you." Catra gave Adora a knowing glance, and Adora knew she was thinking about her turbulent family situation with Shadow Weaver, as well as the passing of her father. Adora sympathetically squeezed Catra's hand.

"Nonsense, you're not imposing at all!" Mara shrugged off Catra's doubts. "We're so happy to have you here." Hope nodded in agreement with her wife.

It didn't take too long for Catra's fears of "imposing" to be assuaged, because Adora's family immediately launched into all of

their Christmas traditions and included Catra in every single one of them. They made Christmas cookies together, did their annual *Home Alone* rewatch, and Adora's moms even got Catra a book for *Jolabokaflod* (the Icelandic tradition of giving books to one's family members on Christmas Eve and reading them together—Hope had heard of it several years ago and had since integrated it into the family's traditions). Adora could tell how overjoyed Catra was, and was pleased that she had invited Catra to come to New York this year. Christmas dinner was the cherry on top; Adora couldn't believe how wonderful it felt to have Catra there, next to her, eating with her family. It was so *right.*

After dinner, Catra and Adora lay on the bed of the guest room, entangled in each other's arms. They were silent at first, drifting off to sleep a bit due to their shared tiredness that had accumulated over a busy twelve days. After a while, Catra delicately uttered her girlfriend's name. "Adora?"

"Yeah?"

"Thank you for making me feel like a part of your family, even though you haven't known me for very long, in the grand scheme of things. I hope you know I'd do the same for you, if I still had blood relatives to call my own."

"You *are* my family, Catra," Adora pressed her forehead to Catra's. She could feel Catra's body relax against hers. "Never forget that."

"I won't. You're my family, too."

Three Years Later

In her office, Adora leaned back into a swivel chair as she examined this year's numbers. Well, the office was a room in Catra's house that had been converted into Adora's workspace, but she couldn't complain. Through the window, she had a view of

emerald-green spruces, and occasionally could see Catra working out there. Adora sifted through the sheets of paper, untucking them from the picture frame she had been using as a paperweight. Inside the frame was a picture from the happiest day of her life—the day she had married Catra on the farm. Adora in a lacy white wedding dress, Catra in a suit, rows of pines behind them, both women looking completely in love. Adora ran her finger over the picture frame, remembering that day; truthfully, her love for Catra had only grown since then. She had worked on the farm with Catra for nearly three trips around the sun, now, and each year only proved to her that she had made the right decision. Sure, Adora went back to New York frequently to visit Mara, Hope and Razz, but she had made a life for herself in Bright Moon with Catra.

"How'd we do this year?" Catra came into the office, wiping her brow. From the looks of it, she had been tending to the trees outside, and thus worked up a sweat. Adora didn't care, though, and kissed her anyway.

Adora then returned her focus to the papers in front of her. "It was our best year yet," Adora announced triumphantly. "Well, the farm's best year, period. Not only did you sell more trees than ever before, but the other attractions—the petting zoo, the sleigh rides—they raked in a lot of extra cash. And it shouldn't surprise you that the concerts are the biggest money-maker of all. A lot of that is thanks to you, you know." She winked at her wife, referencing her frequent performances in "Music Among the Trees". As it turned out, a lot of patrons were interested in the concept of a musically-talented Christmas tree farmer, and the proof was in their concert attendance.

"Don't give me too much credit. I'm pretty sure more people come in to see the song stylings of Sea Hawk's Michael Bublé than Cyra," Catra shrugged. "But, you know what, I'll take the compliment."

"You should. After all, the crowd gave you a thunderous applause at the Christmas Carnival a few days ago," Adora reminded her.

The two of them had gone to the Bright Moon Christmas Carnival every year since Adora had arrived in Bright Moon; luckily, none of them had been as much of a spectacle as Adora's first time there, what with Huntara showing up. (These days, Huntara was engaged to someone else, which Adora had heard about through mutual friends. Adora was glad to know that she had moved on.) However, there was one constant from that first carnival: Catra still made a point of dedicating a song to Adora each year.

"That did feel pretty good," Catra admitted, standing behind Adora and resting her head on her wife's shoulder so she could see the financial records on the desk. "But there was only one person I cared about in the crowd."

"I wonder who that could be," Adora played along with Catra's joke, tittering to herself. Then she turned around in her chair and stood up, her face level with Catra's. "So, Christmas Eve is tomorrow… Is the house ready for my moms and Grandma Razz?"

"It sure is," Catra affirmed. "I've prepared all of the rooms for their stay. I really hope I did a good job, though, because this is the first time they'll be spending Christmas in Bright Moon."

"If they're anything like me—which they are—they'll love it," Adora reassured her. "I can't think of a better place to spend the holidays."

"Well, this place did revive your love of Christmas," Catra teased, placing her hands on Adora's waist.

"You're wrong. That was you." Adora wrapped her arms around Catra.

"To be fair, I can't imagine Christmas without you in it, either," Catra countered.

"Guess you're stuck with me for a while, then." Adora replied, tongue-in-cheek.

Catra booped Adora's nose. "We're *married*, dummy."

“I know. I like to hear you say it, though.” Adora gazed into Catra’s gold-and-blue eyes, remembering the day Catra proposed to her among the rows of Christmas trees. She had proposed two Christmases ago, actually, and of course Adora jumped for joy and said “yes”. They married the summer after that, and all of their friends plus Adora’s family were there to see it. “I can’t wait to spend the rest of my Christmases with you.”

“We’ve got the rest of our lives for that, Adora. But just know, every Christmas that I spend with you ends up being my favorite.” Catra kissed Adora, who couldn’t help but smile into the kiss. This was what Christmas was supposed to be, and she finally had it.

The End

Chapter End Notes

that's it, folks! if you got to the end of this story, thank you so much for reading. i truly appreciate every kudos and comment that i've received on this fic.

i've never written in the she-ra fandom before (i usually write for smaller fandoms) but i have to say i've felt so welcomed and i'm sure i'll be writing for this fandom again ;)

hope you all have a nice new year!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!